

DISRUPTIVE PERSPECTIVES

NO. 29

AGENTS TAKE ON THE BUYING PROCESS

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The purpose of Disruptive Perspectives:

When we analyze different themes, we spend a lot of time using many tools (quarterly reports, analyses, company dialogue, company visits, Excel, calculators and language models). We often make small notes, and sometimes larger notes that we think of as perspectives. We are old enough to know that there are rarely absolute truths, often only different perspectives.

Disruptive Perspectives has only one purpose: to share our perspectives on themes that shape our future. These are not academic papers, encyclopedia entries or recommendations to do, buy or sell anything. Just good old-fashioned information sharing to show how we view different themes at the time of publication. Perspectives do not become smaller when shared, perhaps rather larger. With that as our starting point, enjoy the journey through our perspectives.

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Disclaimer

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We have created and written a framework that we have discussed in many contexts, including several Disruptive Perspectives notes. Among other things, we use the four horsemen as an analytical framework for how work, companies and capital markets are being rewritten as human hands, feet and cognitive processes are fully and partly

replaced by digital and physical agents. Two of the horsemen are especially close. Digital agents, which take on cognitive tasks, and voice agents (what we often call relationship-oriented speech), which make language the interface between human and machine.

We define the agent concept simply. An agent is "an intermediary that does something on behalf of others". Digital agents execute, plan and learn in software. Voice agents are not just an interface (voice UI). They are the horseman that ties the others together by turning intention into action without fingers, menus and keyboards. Words and human speech are the new link between human and machine. It does not change everything. But it changes a lot.

Postcards From The Future

The difference between Digital agents & Voice agents

	Digital Agents	**Voice Agents**
Function	Replaces cognitive processes: planning, reasoning, calling tools, completing workflows	Replaces the finger-based interface: voice as command and relationship
Ontology	Autonomous software entity in an environment (APIs, files, other agents)	Interface horseman that turns will into action in digital and physical systems
Typical form	Coding agents, research agents, workflow orchestration	Voice in chat, AR glasses, cars, humanoids, customer service
Economic logic	Labour substitution and scale at near-zero marginal cost	Loyalty, habits and an "emotional moat" around an assistant

In short, the distinction is analytical, not ontological. Put a little more fully, digital agents and voice agents are two ways of describing the same type of system. In reality, a modern voice agent is simply a digital agent that acts through language. A mature voice agent is often a digital agent with speech as its primary channel. We distinguish between them because they disrupt different **bottlenecks**. The head vs the hand as the interface to the machines.

To broaden our range of perspectives, we take a short tour of theories about agents. Those who have read our Disruptive Perspectives notes know that we respect

theorists, because those of us who analyze the future know there is no empirical evidence about the future. Only mental maps and theories.

Russell & Norvig define an agent as something that perceives its environment and acts upon it. We and others have extended this with autonomy, goal complexity, generality and tool use. A digital agent is therefore not a better chatbot, but a decision system that coordinates plan, memory, tools and environment over time.

Christensen describes low-end products and services that climb up the market with their disruption, and Schumpeter describes how new combinations tear down old structures. We often apply these concepts to work. Hands, feet and cognitive processes as factors of production are replaced by capital (physical and digital agents). Voice commands are the "paradigm-shifting" component here in Kuhn's sense, as we move from transactional UI (clicks, forms, apps) to relational UI (conversation, intention, trust).

We also often apply S-curves and the convergence of different innovation platforms. We have previously placed the horsemen on overlapping S-curves. Digital agents and voice agents reach their inflection point around 2025–2026. In our mental maps they will merge (converge) with physical and self-driving agents and produce "super-exponential" growth, because the interface lowers the cost of adoption. A very important theory here is Metcalfe's law and the flywheel effect. The latter can be illustrated empirically:

more use → more data → better model → more use

For voice agents, this flywheel becomes relational. Habit and loyalty, not just function. The technological superstructure moves from a transaction-oriented technology to a relationship-based technology. We humans will develop different values and attitudes towards a machine that talks to you than towards a machine where you push buttons and knobs to give a command.

Earlier digitalization (online banking, apps, search) was transaction-oriented. When fingers are replaced by words, relationships, emotions and loyalty towards the machine emerge. "We are going to become loyal to the machines," we say. That changes switching costs and brand logic more than it changes technical performance.

In our search for theories that can broaden our perspectives, organizational theory through Weber & Taylor is also central. In our notes they reappear as the "machine bureaucracy". Digital agents formalize procedures, voice agents make the chain of command oral and continuous. McKinsey calls it *the agentic organization*. Humans, virtual and physical agents in the same workflow. The gains come from redesigned workflows, not from gluing an agent onto existing tasks.

Is there any empirical evidence on digital agents? McKinsey's State of AI 2026 shows that 40% of large companies are scaling AI agents (up from 27% the year before) and about 2 in 10 are scaling coding agents. 32 % have stopped buying software because they can build it in-house with agentic tools. At the same time, 80 % report individual productivity gains, while only 39 % see an EBIT effect at company level. In Technology Trends Outlook 2026, productivity fell in nearly 30 % of companies after introducing agentic coding tools. Code activity rose more than 180 %, shipped releases only +30 % (Source). 46 % of developers distrust the accuracy. Capital is nevertheless running ahead. Equity investment in agentic software passed USD 61 billion in the first half of 2026.

Can we interpret this as the technology being at its inflection point while the organization lags behind? Agents without redesigned processes create more noise than value.

And voice agents? Menlo Ventures' 2026 consumer survey shows that 19 % of AI users have voice as their primary channel, and another 27 % switch between speaking and typing. At the same time, classic assistants are declining. Alexa 32% → 22 %, Siri 25% → 20 %. People were trained to use them for timers and playlists, and expect nothing more. That is precisely the difference between a voice command without action and a voice agent. G2 data (2025–2026) shows 88 % of platforms with rapidly increasing adoption and 76 % reporting significant or transformative ROI from voice AI. AR glasses (Meta Ray-Ban, Google, Apple racing towards 2026 production) are, to

us, a concrete “iPhone moment” for voice agents. Hands free, context in your field of view, voice as the command.

What about the labour market? Goldman Sachs’ estimate that generative AI could automate work equivalent to hundreds of millions of jobs, particularly office jobs, is used by the authors as a backdrop. McKinsey Global Institute estimates that today’s technology could theoretically automate more than half of US working hours, and that partnerships between people, agents and robots could unlock around USD 2.9 trillion in annual value in the US by 2030 if workflows are redesigned. 39 % of companies expect AI-related reductions in headcount next year.

The empirical evidence is therefore twofold. Individual and capital acceleration, organizational and trust-related friction. That is a typical inflection point on the S-curve, not counter-evidence. Or so we believe.

Postcards From The Future

Human and machine meet through text vs voice

	Low autonomy (answers, waits)	**High autonomy** (plans, acts, learns)
Text	**ChatGPT style: generative assistant**	**Digital agents** **coding, research, ERP orchestration**
Voice (natural language)	**Classic VUI: Alexa & Siri (timers, music)**	**Voice agents** **intention → tools → action in the world**

As we move from transaction-oriented to relationship-oriented technology, a lot happens to our relationship with the machines.

Transaction-oriented vs. Relationship-oriented

	Transaction-oriented	Relationship-oriented
Digital core	**Forms, RPA, search, "click here"**	**Digital agent as colleague:** **memory, preferences, continuity**
Linguistic core	**Voice search and IVR**	**Voice agent:** **loyalty, habit, "I talk to my agent" My digital buddy**

This is the basis for our claim that switching bank, shop or OS becomes harder when the relationship sits in the voice, not in the app. Sometimes there are "first mover advantages" (vs first to scale). This may be one of those times.

Digital agents and voice agents are complementary, not competing. The first attacks what can be done without human cognition. The second attacks how will is expressed. Without voice agents, digital agents remain an expert tool behind a screen. Without digital agents, speech remains a dressed-up IVR system.

A kind of summary that carries a lot of force. Call it a one-sentence synthesis: *Digital agents change the production function, voice agents change the demand and loyalty function. Where they meet, the division of labour is rewritten from Smith's human specialization to a three-way split: human, digital agent and linguistic interface.*

And in September 2026 we moved much closer to this. **Meta Muse** was introduced, and **Instinct** and **Grok Bot** carry much of the same message. The digital agents that work for us in the digital world have begun scaling to our AI glasses, phones, PCs and cars. The digital agents are now being tied to hardware form factors. The three products are empirical examples of what we call digital agents bound together by voice agents. They are not physical agents (humanoids, robots). They are software agents that can control physical form factors: phone, PC, car, humanoid, glasses and

wearables. The difference between them is where they live, who they are made for, and which hardware ecosystem they can grow into.

1.0 The three digital agents

Meta Muse (launched 8 September 2026) is a consumer agent. A named assistant that does work, not just answers. It runs in an isolated virtual machine in the cloud with its own browser (Muse Secure VM), has the Sentinel oversight process, and asks for approval before email, payment and other irreversible actions. The channels are its own app, muse.ai and WhatsApp. Integrations include Gmail, Instagram, Facebook, Spotify, OpenTable, Ticketmaster and Stripe Link (single-use cards). The core model is free, Power costs USD 20, but at most USD 100 a month. Zuckerberg's framing is that Muse will work "24/7 on your behalf" with goals, health, relationships and finances.

Instinct (Noah Shinn / Spear Street Technology) is the viral, invitation-only life assistant that lives in messages (iMessage and WhatsApp) without a new app. The agent gets its own email address, can log in (1Password, TOTP), knows your location, and has from 16 September 2026 a Concierge that calls US businesses (a restaurant without online booking, a dentist waiting list, a cable bill). The valuation has gone from a USD 50 million seed in spring 2026, to a Series B at 2.5 billion in August, and now talks of a new 1 billion round at around 10 billion in September. More than 100,000 users have already been reported.

Grok Bot (xAI, beta 11 August 2026) is an army of assistants, not a single life coach. Each Bot has its own cloud PC (browser, file system, terminal), memory and routines, and can talk to other Bots. The metaphor is a team, not a butler. Access is bundled into SuperGrok and Cursor subscriptions. Enterprise opened on 3 September with access, network and audit logs. The Galaxy event on 15–17 September showed three employees building a company in 72 hours with Grok Bot as the workforce, plus a Voice Agent API at USD 0.08 per minute. Grok already sits in the Tesla ("Hey Grok, take me to the ATM") and is the obvious candidate as the brain for Optimus and Cybercab.

Three Digital agents & Voice agents

	Agent type	Primary user	Interface	Runtime
Meta Muse	Digital agent + voice agent for life coordination	Consumer, mass chat	WhatsApp, glasses soon	Isolated VM + Sentinel
Instinct	Voice agent first: intention via SMS becomes action	Consumer, early adopter	iMessage/WhatsApp, voice, phone	Agent with its own accounts
Grok Bot	Digital agents in a flock; work, not life	Knowledge work + Tesla ecosystem	Desktop, iOS, voice, potentially car/robot	Shared/own cloud PC per bot

Muse and Instinct compete for life. For how to coordinate our everyday lives. Grok Bot competes for work and, through Tesla, for the body (car, humanoid). All three indicate the 2026 inflection point we have discussed in many contexts. The digital agents are taking over from the chatbot.

Adoption and capital confirm the S-curve. Muse reached second place in the US App Store; early Sensor Tower figures suggested around 83,000 iOS downloads in 2 days. Instinct went from private beta to a billion-dollar valuation in months. Grok Bot was pulled out of internal SpaceX/xAI use (sales, support, engineering) and opened to enterprise. Instinct's Resy episode and Muse's heavy approval layer are two sides of the same coin. High autonomy without clear rules causes harm, too much human in the loop kills some of the magic.

Voice is the empirical bridge to voice agents. Muse and Instinct added outbound calls the same week (16 September 2026). xAI prices voice aggressively. Tesla documents that FSD Supervised with Grok feels like "your own robotaxi": "Hey Grok, take me to the ATM". That is really our relationship shift in one sentence: **The fingers are gone, the word is the command, the agent is the intermediary.**

Trust is the limiting factor. Muse launches two weeks after a major Meta settlement over the harmful effects of social media, and still asks for email, calendar, health and payment cards.

1.1 Form factors. Where digital agents and voice agents meet “physical” surfaces

We distinguish physical agents (body) from digital ones. The form factors below are the bodies the agents can move into. None of the three are humanoids. All three can become the operating system on top of them.

1. **Phone**. Instinct wins here. The product is the messaging app you already open. Muse is a separate app plus WhatsApp. Meta owns the distribution. Grok Bot has iOS, but is more desktop-first. The phone is the transitional form factor we give 15 years before glasses take over. All three use it as a voice agent channel (text + speech + eventually calls).
2. **PC**. Grok Bot is the only one designed as a co-worker on the machine. Terminal, files, Cursor, routines, several bots in a group chat. Muse has a web VM you can watch, but it is life admin, not an IDE. Instinct uses the PC only as yet another inbox. For knowledge work, the PC is still where digital agents create measurable output (and where McKinsey’s 180/30 paradox arises).
3. **Car / robotaxi.** Here Grok alone is empirically inside the form factor. Tesla is rolling out Grok as cabin control and navigation voice; the company itself has equated “FSD Supervised w/ Grok” with owning your own robotaxi. A Cybercab without a steering wheel makes voice the only UI. A pure voice agent. Muse and Instinct are relevant as bookers (the trip, a restaurant after arrival), not as the driving stack.
4. **Humanoids**. Early scale, but the architecture is visible. “Digital Optimus” was described as Grok (system 2, planning) on top of Tesla’s visual executor (system 1). Muse/Instinct could in principle become the command layer (”tidy the kitchen”, “bring the bag”) via voice, but they do not own the body. A physical agent without a digital/voice agent is a puppet. A digital agent without a body is a butler behind the screen. The convergence we call the intersection is precisely a Grok-like brain + an Optimus-like body.
5. **AI glasses**. Muse has the shortest path, Meta owns Ray-Ban/Oakley/its own Meta Glasses, Muse Spark is already in the glasses, the Muse agent is “coming

soon", and Luna (a camera-free model) is reported to have a dedicated Muse/AI button plus six microphones. Grok Bot has been demonstrated as a mascot on Even G2 glasses. Instinct has no optics of its own. Glasses are one of the candidates to replace the phone, freeing the hands, getting context from the camera, voice as the command. They are the voice agent's native hardware.

6. **Other wearables** (watch, earbuds, ring, body-worn sensor). The weakest evidence for these three in particular, but the logic is the same as for glasses. Instinct's messaging DNA suits a watch ("sort it out"). Muse's goal and health integration suits the Apple Health/Withings connections it already has. Grok's voice in an earbud is a natural extension of the Tesla cabin. Wearables are the relationship surface, not where the agent does the work (that happens in the virtual machine in the cloud).

Postcards From The Future

Who the digital agent is for and where it lives

	Life & consumer	**Work & business**
In an existing messaging app	**Instinct (iMessage/WhatsApp)**	**Instinct can be misused for work, but is not managed**
Own runtime + ecosystem	**Muse (app, WhatsApp, glasses, Meta graph)**	**Grok Bot (cloud PC, Cursor, enterprise audit, Tesla)**

Muse is the polished digital + voice agent with a path into glasses. Instinct is the purest voice agent of 2026. You write as you would to a person, and it acts in the world, including making calls. Grok Bot is the flock of digital agents with the only credible bridge to two of our other horsemen or innovation platforms. Self-driving and humanoids. That is because Grok already sits in the Tesla and is intended as Optimus's system 2.

The form factors are not neutral shells. Phone and PC favour Instinct and Grok Bot respectively. Glasses favour Muse. Car and humanoid favour Grok, so far as a thesis plus cabin evidence, not as a finished "physical agent". Wearables amplify the voice agent, they are not an executing body. They could become the hardware platform for, for example, OpenAI.

Theoretically, this is the convergence of innovation platforms we have often described. Digital agents take cognition, voice agents take the interface, physical form factors take the hands and feet. Empirically, in 2026 we are still in the upper half of the matrices, with the first fragile entries in cars and glasses. In our own words, the horsemen are visible, but they are not yet riding in step.

1.2 Does it matter? Is there any disruption here?

Christensen's point is that disruption does not strike at the top first. It takes the "good enough" at the bottom (cheap, simple, often overlooked) and climbs. The agents are doing the same with purchasing. First USD 50 digital goods and a restaurant, then travel, insurance and cars. When fingers, eyes and screens drop out of the loop, the app stops being a shop. **It becomes a pipe**. Catalogue, stock status, price, terms and settlement that another party's agent can call.

McKinsey estimates that agentic commerce could orchestrate up to USD 1 trillion in US B2C sales by 2030, and 3–5 trillion globally. Accenture simulates that up to 45 % of shoppers move at least half of their shopping into agent-mediated ecosystems within 18–24 months. That is not "more digitalization". **It is a change of decision-maker.**

Three shifts at once

1. **Disruption from below.** Siri/Alexa were too poor to destroy Amazon. Muse, Instinct and Grok Bot are "good enough" at bookings, email and small purchases, and are getting payment pipes (Stripe Link, ACP) and the phone. When disruptive performance overtakes what the market actually needs, the old cost curve collapses (Christensen).

2. **The app as a pipe.** Karpathy's phrasing that software written for humans is being rewritten for agents is precise. The human does not open Expedia. The agent queries WebMCP/UCP, reads the terms by machine and pays. The website becomes a verification layer, not a brochure. Gartner has long warned of a decline in classic search volume; SISTRIX shows CTR in position 1 falling from 27 to 11 % when an AI Overview appears. The click economy is already undermined. Agent purchasing removes the click entirely.
3. **Buying without a body**. Worldpay believes that around 50 % will trust an agent for digital goods under GBP 50; 30–34 % for physical retail under GBP 50; 19–24 % for travel up to GBP 1,000. Trust climbs up the price scale in the same pattern Christensen describes. Muse with the Stripe guarantee and Instinct Concierge are the evidence in September 2026.

1.3 Which business models are destroyed

Destroyed does not mean the industry disappears. It means the revenue logic that owns the relationship dies.

Search, display and affiliate. The value lay in owning the eye between intention and click. The agent cuts the journey from 10 searches to one task. Ad space along the funnel shrinks. Long-tail media without subscriptions are the most exposed. Licensing to model companies and "generative engine optimization" are lean substitutes, not the same margins.

Comparison sites and pure UI OTAs. Those who only own the screen, and not inventory or contracts, become channels, or disappear. Executive surveys in travel already rank AI-native surfaces ahead of brands on the question of who owns the relationship.

The app economy as attention rent. The super-app taxed the eye. When Instinct lives in iMessage and Muse in WhatsApp, "download our app" is a rejected step. The App Store cut remains for publishers, but acquisition via ASO and splash screens dies. Loyalty moves to the agent. Or so we believe.

The agencies' execution layer. Hourly rates for posts, SEO articles, bid management and reports are the Christensen classic, i.e. surplus performance the customer does not want to pay for. Agents bring this to near-zero marginal cost. What survives is brand, negotiation and crisis, not the production itself.

Intermediaries that charge a fee to "make it easy". Bill negotiation, stand-alone insurance aggregation, basic tax advice, "we call the cable company for you". Instinct Concierge is that product.

1.4 Which business models change

Changed means that volume can grow, while who wins internally shifts.

Retail and brands. Demand does not disappear. The shelf the agent sees is machine-readable, such as price, stock, returns, sustainability, delivery time and compatibility. Accenture reports that 86 % of agent-mediated transactions risk being abandoned or switched if something fails in the purchase. The winner is the one that is flawless for the agent, not the one with the prettiest app. Private labels and "good enough" goods win more often when the agent optimizes for price/specification, not brand story. Unless the brand is coded as a preference in the user's agent ("always brand X").

Travel and hotels. The highest net new demand and high execution risk in Accenture's map. The whole holiday in one sentence is a use case Muse/Instinct are already selling. Flights and hotels become inventory + policy APIs. Loyalty programmes must be readable and redeemable by the agent, otherwise the ones that differentiate die. OTAs survive only if they own inventory, settlement or unique terms. Not if they own a search form.

Payments, banking and cards. The agent wallet (single-use cards, mandates and quotas) becomes the new core. The bank's app is the channel. Whoever issues the agent's payment identity and takes the risk of mistaken purchases (Stripe already offers a guarantee for Muse) takes the fee that used to sit in interchange + app experience.

Insurance and financial products. Standardized policies are agent food. Compare, switch and negotiate. Advice involving judgement and regulated liability changes more slowly. Distribution via human agents/brokers is squeezed from the low end.

Subscriptions and streaming. The agent cancels what you forgot (Instinct evidence) and switches when prices rise. "Set it and forget it" business models see higher churn. What survives is content and bundles the agent cannot substitute, or contracts the agent is not allowed to touch.

SaaS and ERP. 32 % of companies have stopped buying at least one software product because coding agents could build it. ERP as a screen surface for humans is challenged by agent layers on top of the data. Per-seat licensing is dying slowly; licensing per agent action or per outcome is coming.

Cars and mobility. Buying cars and spare parts ranks high on Accenture's shift map. Robotaxi + "Hey Grok, take me there" removes both the dealer experience and app-hailing as a relationship surface. Uber/Lyft become pipes or fleets. The brand in the car becomes the voice you can stand sitting with.

Property, electricity, telecom. Highly standardizable switches (electricity contracts, mobile plans, home insurance) are classic low-end disruption. Buying a home itself remains hybrid: the agent filters, the human goes to the viewing.

Health and pharmacy. Low-risk goods and appointment booking go first. Records, prescriptions and liability keep the human in the loop for longer.

1.5 New business models

These barely existed as separate categories before the agent became the buyer.

1. The agent platform as relationship owner - Muse, Instinct, Grok Bot take a cut or a subscription for being the shop.
2. Agent-ready infrastructure - UCP, WebMCP, catalogues, inventory APIs, machine-readable terms. "Shopify for agents".
3. Agent identity and mandate - who may use which card, up to which limit, with which right of return.

4. Error and dispute insurance for agents - Muse's Stripe guarantee generalized.
5. AEO/GEO - visibility inside the agent's shortlist, not on page 1 of Google.
6. Outcome-based agencies and "vibe-setting" - strategy and brand, not hours.
7. Exception handling as a service - humans who take over when the agent gets stuck (courtesy, law, judgement).
8. Compute, energy and edge - our picks-and-shovels when millions of agents run 24/7.
9. Brand-for-agents, such as trust signals, certification and end-user preferences stored with the user's agent, not in your CRM.

Postcards From The Future

Standardizability and disruption

	Low value & frequent	**High value & rare**
Homogeneous & highly standardized	**Destroyed first** Small buys, power, subscriptions, basic insurance, takeaway	**Changed hard** flights, hotels, electronics, car cover
High degree of judgement, senses, trust	**Changed slowly** fashion "for fun", local café	**Lasts the longest** surgery, housing, lawyers, luxury experiences

The agent takes the upper left, then the lower left, then the upper right. The lower right is where fingers and eyes still matter, but the agent has already filtered the field.

Postcards From The Future

What happens to the business models?

	Owned by brand or app	**Owned by middlemen today**
New owner: the user's agent	Brand becomes a pipe + preference file (Nike, SAS, Tesla)	OTAs, aggregators, app stores lost to Muse/Instinct/Grok
New owner: infrastructure	Payment, identity, catalogue API (Stripe, Shopify, UCP)	Search ads and affiliate replaced by AEO fees and licensing AEO: Answer Engine Optimization GEO: Generative Engine Optimization AEO & GEO are a kind of "fee" brands must pay to be chosen by an agent. Buying agents vs answering agents

Postcards From The Future

Sector business models in motion

Sector	**Destroyed business model (BM)**	**Changed BM**	**New business model (BM)**
Search/media	Clicks, display, thin SEO page	Brand + licence	AEO, content-to-model
Travel	UI OTA, metasearch	Flights/hotels as inventory	Agent-first OTA, error insurance
Retail	App as destination	Brand + logistics	Agent catalogue, preference files
Payments	Banking app as experience	Card and account as pipe	Agent mandate, single-use cards
Insurance	Pure price aggregation	Policy + claims	Continuous switching agent
Software	Seat licence for a single function	Platform + data	Agents that build replacements
Marketing	Hourly execution	Strategy/brand	Outcome agency, agent network
Mobility	Hailing app as brand	Fleet and energy	Voice OS in the car
Subscriptions	Dormant revenue	Content	Agent that switches for you
Prof. services	Standardizable junior work	Liability and relationship	Exception desk for agents

Not everything is Christensen. Some markets have regulation, liability and the body as a ceiling. Health, law, children, physical experiences. There, the agent becomes a filter, not a buyer.

The core is nevertheless simple. When the eye and the finger were the bottleneck, whoever owned the screen won. When the agent is the buyer, the winner is whoever is readable, reliable and cheap enough for a machine, plus whoever owns the

machine the user is loyal to. The app becomes a pipe. The pipe becomes the business model. The relationship sits with the voice agent.

1.6 Travel and tourism

Travel is a sector where Christensen's low-end logic and "the app as a pipe" perhaps collide hardest. The product is already digital, prices are comparable, the trip is a chain of suppliers, and trust breaks exactly when the agent is about to swipe the card. That is why travel is both the biggest opportunity and the slowest to complete.

What "travel agents" actually are

There are at least five kinds of agents in the same value chain. They are often confused.

1. Horizontal life agents – Muse, Instinct, ChatGPT, Gemini, Grok. Travel is one task among email and bills. Instinct calls the restaurant that does not take online bookings and Muse books travel in its own VM. They own the intention, not the airline seat.

2. OTA agents – Booking.com AI Trip Planner and Priceline's Penny; Expedia's Romie; Trip.com TripGenie; Kayak AI. They sit on inventory and checkout, but the conversation usually ends on their payment page. Penny is reported to have higher conversion and CSAT, on a small sample.

3. AI-native planners – Mindtrip (live GDS via Sabre + PayPal checkout in the chat from May 2026) and Layla. Expedia bought Layla to own the inspiration layer before it becomes the channel and infrastructure for others. Or the "pipe", as we call it.

4. Platform agents – Google AI Mode with Booking, Expedia, Marriott, IHG, Choice and Wyndham as merchant of record. Google owns the habit, the partner owns the money. ChatGPT has Booking and Expedia as apps inside the chat, with handover to their checkout.

5. Operational agents at suppliers and TMCs – Ixigo monitors prices, checks in, fetches boarding passes, calls the hotel and chases refunds. Navan is a concrete example, as is Air India, which brings booking and payment into its own app with

generative AI throughout the trip. Ascott exposes inventory directly in other companies' AI assistants.

2.0 Introduction to the buying process

This part of the note starts with a sentence that used to require an evening of effort and the certainty that the result would hardly be optimal. The algorithms online had an expensive alliance with cookies and search history. Classic marketing assumes that value is created by shaping human preference under uncertainty. In an agentic market, preference is shaped before exposure, and uncertainty is reduced by data. Large parts of the marketing machinery then become a cost centre for legitimacy, not a growth engine.

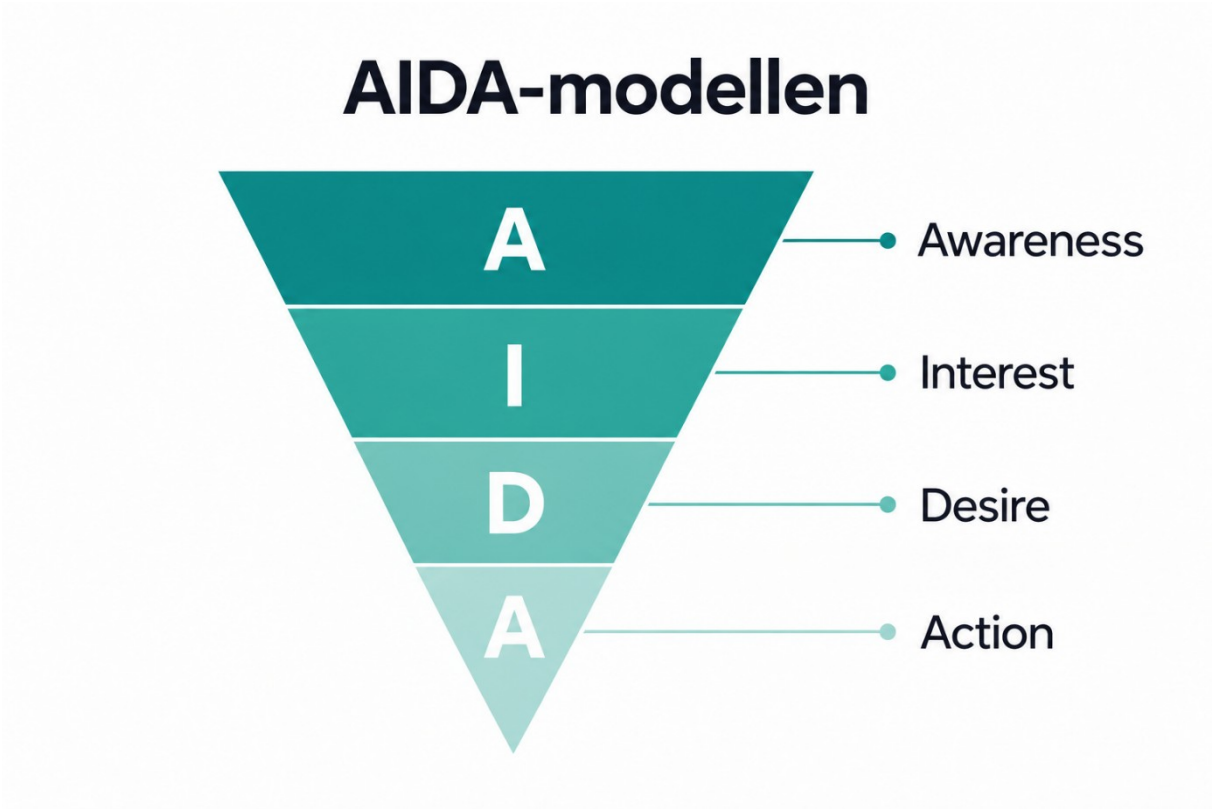
"Find a trip to Norway in September. Two adults. Train if possible. No cruise. Good food. Keep it under twenty thousand."

Before, we sat with two tabs, a map and a bad mood when the credit card had to be entered twice. A guilty conscience when you had to call and be firm because something went wrong anyway. **Now** the sentence goes to an agent. It searches, compares, books flights and rooms, and comes back with a proposal. You say yes. Money and booking have changed hands before the destination film has even downloaded.

That is the challenge, stated without theory and evidence. A kind of superstructure for this note. Marketing, reputation and the buying process will never be the same again. Anyone trying to get more people to travel, stay, see and eat is increasingly talking to the wrong person. The advertising is made for a human with eyes and a thumb. The purchase is carried out by a digital agent, a kind of proxy with a mandate from you, a catalogue of choices and preferences, and a credit card.

Three problems are connected.

The first is **the buying process**. The old customer journey (need, search, evaluation, purchase and after-sales) assumed that you yourself sat in the middle. AIDA (Awareness, Interest, Desire, Action) assumed that someone had to see you before anyone could choose you. When the word replaces the finger, the middle of the process is delegated. The human, you and I, owns the mandate. The digital agent owns the execution.



The second is **reputation** as lock-in. Brands and destinations have spent years charging themselves with **signals** that the market and the wider field like: purpose, icons, "powered by nature", the right attitude, values and a snapshot of whatever the field perceives as good. Some of this is capital. Some is debt. It costs to have said something last year that narrows the room for what you need to say this year. In travel it looks like the queue to the same five places in July, while the strategy says the whole country and the whole year. The marketing of Lofoten was too good last year, and the room for manoeuvre this year became smaller.

The third is **the platform**. Booking, Google and now Meta Muse do not own Norway. They own the road there. Visibility becomes inventory, data and rules a machine can read, not an award-winning film. When a human buys, a landing page, a film and a

nice picture can carry the product. When a digital agent is the "buyer", it needs rows it can compare. We call the sum of all rows a **catalogue**. A row stating what the product is, what it costs, whether it is available now, when it can be delivered, how it can be cancelled, where it is located and which rules apply.

Becoming "the row in the table" and being a "clean catalogue" becomes what matters. The digital agent does not open your mood. It opens the inventory (the rows) in the catalogue.

"Norway is magical" is not a catalogue. "Double room in Drammen 12–14 September, NOK 1,980, free cancellation up to 7 days before, dinner bookable until 19:30" is a catalogue.

Without a catalogue, the brand is invisible to whoever completes the purchase, even if the destination film has won industry awards.

2.1 Key concepts for understanding digital agents in marketing

Job-to-be-done is what the customer actually hires you for. The job is concrete. In travel it is never "experience Norway". It is a night, a view, a dinner, a safe September, northern lights in week 8. **Mandate** is the sentence the principal (you and me) gives the agent. **Catalogue** is no longer the paper brochure, but the machine-readable inventory of what you sell. **Corpus** is all the language and digital traces a digital agent has to go on when it knows something about you (brand, destination or product). The corpus is your reputation as the digital agent has picked it up (reviews, articles, forums, price lists, queue stories, campaign copy, newspaper stories, TripAdvisor's top lists, "expensive in July", "magical fjords"). **Reputational debt** is signals that earned applause, and that later take away room for manoeuvre. **Agent capital** is being a row, or a rule, in the utility function that chooses. **Moat** is what still earns a premium when the eye is gone and the catalogue remains.

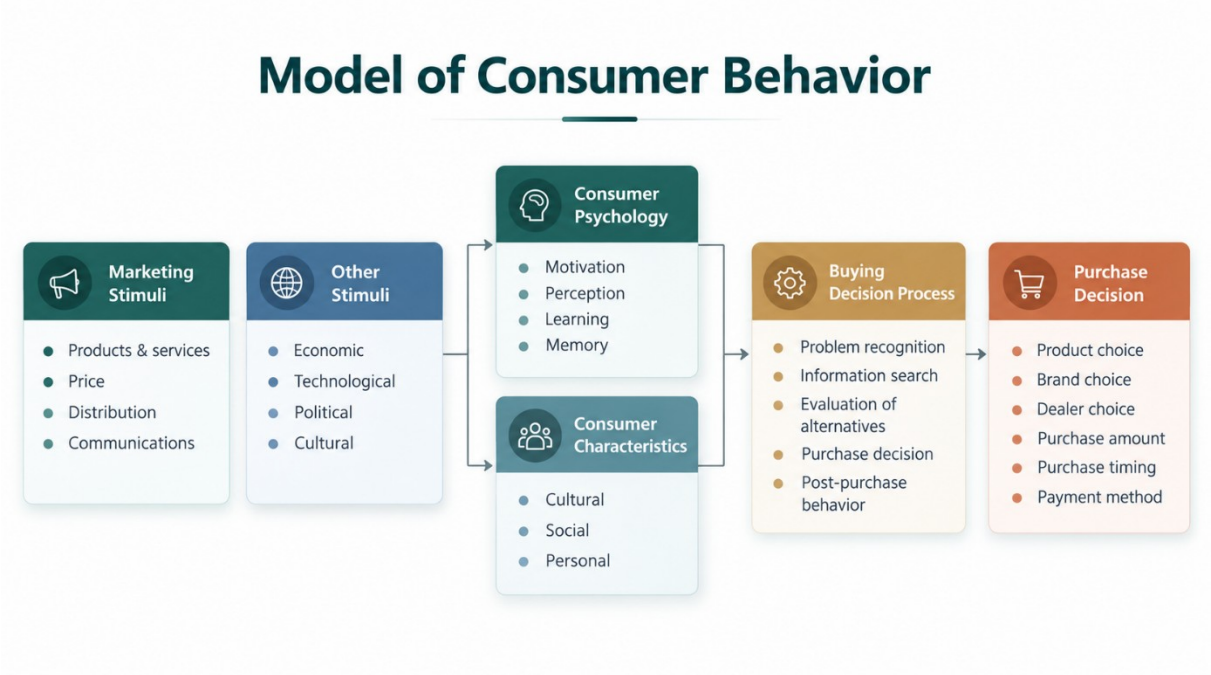
There are many reflections, and many questions that can be explored from this starting point.

If the agent is the buyer, what is a brand or a destination worth? Which part of the budget builds the job, and which part pays interest on old signals? Who owns the mandate in five years: you, the OTA, the glasses or the agent? And how do we get more people to travel, sleep, see and eat here, if "more" is to mean more of the right nights, not just more bodies in the queue for what we have already sold well?

Imagine that the purchase has already been made while you still think you are in the shop. You have said a word, pointed at an object, given a budget and a veto (a decision rule). The rest – search, comparison, negotiation, payment, return policy – is carried out by a digital agent or proxy that neither gets bored in a feed nor needs to feel like a good person at the checkout. **Meta Muse was** as mentioned launched in the US on 8 September 2026, with an announced path into AI glasses. This is one of the postcards we have drawn for many years, calling it the four horsemen riding into working life, business and the capital markets. Physical agents, self-driving agents through cars and drones, digital agents, and voice technology as a bridge between human and machine.

This Disruptive Perspectives note is not about the glasses as a gadget. It is about the subject the glasses move. Classic marketing and the classic buying process assume a human who sees, doubts, desires and clicks. Is it being disrupted now? Not just by AI glasses, which are only one form factor where the digital agents can live.

"AIDA" and "Kotler's five stages" are maps of that human. Brand equity is an assumption that someone will pay more, or switch less, because they have seen the brand. Reputation is an assumption that the field (press, employees, stock index, jury, politicians) and, ultimately, the customer are the same judge.



Creative destruction (Schumpeter)

New combinations of technology, organization and market destroy old revenue models. Marketing as "persuading a human in front of a screen" is one such combination. When the agent takes over search, comparison and payment, it is not just a channel that is destroyed, but the whole need to persuade a human.

Disruptive innovation (Christensen)

A simpler, cheaper or more "good-enough" solution starts in a segment the incumbents ignore, and then takes the core. Digital agents first look like an assistant ("order milk"). Then they take the whole job ("make sure the household has what it needs at the lowest total cost given my preferences"). That is Jobs-to-be-Done: the customer is not buying an advertising experience, but a finished outcome.

Paradigm shift (Kuhn)

The old paradigm: brand + attention + emotion + loyalty in the human. The new: preference profile + constraint set + trust signals + API access in the agent. Anomalies (people stop scrolling, stop "feeling the brand", stop completing the purchase themselves) accumulate into a shift in what counts as "good marketing".

Porter's five forces / positioning

When the agent is the buyer, the balance of power changes: switching costs fall (the agent switches supplier in seconds), supplier power rises for those who own data and checkout (Meta, Stripe/Link, platforms), and differentiation that only lives in an advertising film becomes irrelevant. Positioning must withstand machine-readable comparison.

Metcalfe's law

The value of an agent network grows with the number of connected services, identities and transactions. Muse + glasses + Stripe Link + Instagram/Facebook history is not a product, it is a network of rights to act. Whoever first owns the trust to act on your behalf gets super-linear returns.

Blue ocean

Competing for human attention is a red ocean (the same banner, the same influencer, the same ESG campaign). The blue ocean lies in becoming the agent's preferred default: structured product data, reliable delivery, return guarantees, predictable quality, low friction for autonomous checkout.

Regulatory capture

When regulation, industry norms and "best practice" are written by incumbents and their stakeholder machinery, yesterday's model is protected. In marketing: advertising

bans, brand codes, ESG reporting and reputation regimes that favour visible value positioning over actual customer value.

Institutional theory (DiMaggio & Powell et al.)

Organizations do not just adapt to the market, but to the field of legitimacy. Three isomorphisms:

- Coercive: laws, supervision, procurement requirements, ESG indices
- Mimetic: "everyone else has a Pride campaign / DEI film / purpose platform"
- Normative: communications education, agencies, juries and industry awards

We return to these isomorphisms in chapter 4.2. The outcome may be that marketing optimizes for recognition within the field, not for conversion with the end customer.

Technical debt

Short-term choices (shortcuts in code, architecture and integrations) that provide speed now, but constrain the room for manoeuvre later. Interest is paid as inertia, risk and an inability to change.

Reputational/institutional debt (working concept)

Similar to technical debt. Short-term reputation and positioning choices that provide legitimacy now (employees, media, investors, regulators, "the verdict of the street and the court of Theatercaféen"), but narrow who you can speak to, which products you can sell, and which signals the agent will later trust. Interest is paid as a lost core base, brand confusion and strategic self-censorship. Reputational lock-in is the popular label for one visible form of interest, not the whole phenomenon.

The classic buying process

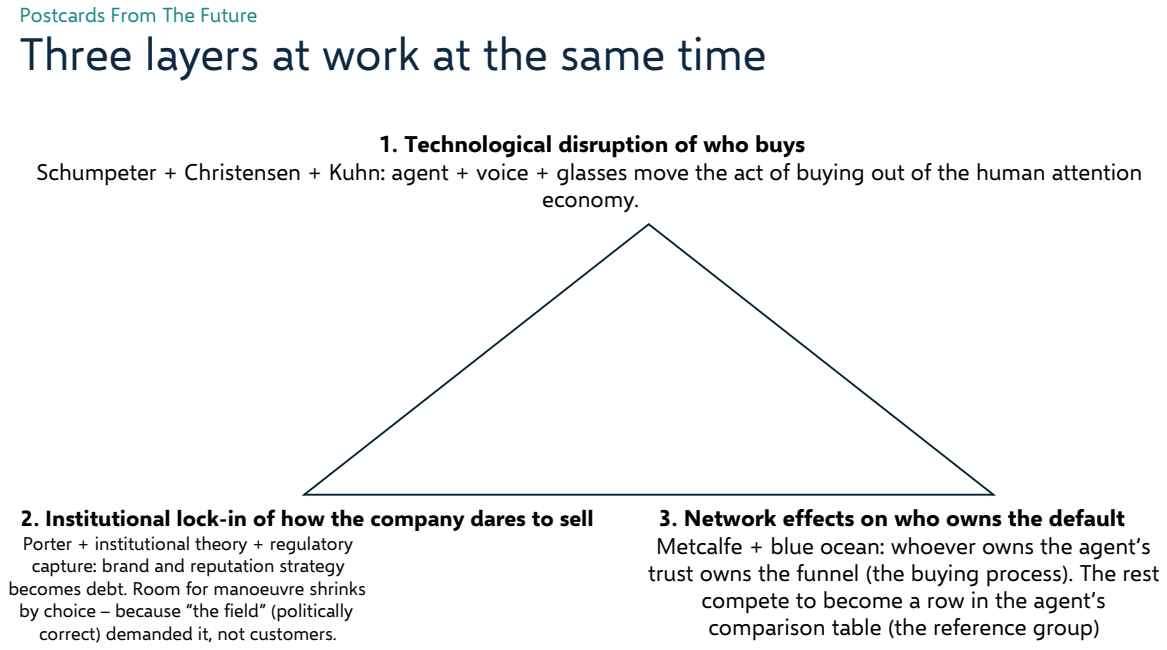
Need → information search → evaluation → choice → purchase → post-purchase.

In AIDA: **Attention–Interest–Desire–Action.**

The whole funnel assumes a human subject who sees, feels and clicks.

The agentic buying process

The human sets goals, constraints and level of trust. The agent searches, negotiates, filters, checks out and follows up. Meta Muse can open a browser, fill in forms, negotiate and pay via Stripe Link; glasses make the command situated ("that jacket", "top up", "switch supplier"). The subject in the funnel moves.



The analogy: technical debt vs reputational debt

Technical debt	Reputational/marketing debt
Quick hack that "works in prod"	Campaign that "works in the media"
Hidden complexity in the code	Hidden contradiction in the brand
Each new feature costs more	Each new position must be squared with the last signal
Refactoring is postponed	Repositioning is postponed ("we can't say that anymore")
The system crashes under load	The brand crashes when the core base or the agent ignores the signal

The point is not morality. The point is optionality, room for manoeuvre. The more the brand is loaded with identity signals not tied to the product's job, the less robust it is when the buyer stops being a human who needs to "feel right" and becomes an agent that must "hit constraints", the buying instructions given to the digital agent by the human.

3.0 Is a big bang coming? A disruption of the buying process?

An anomaly in Kuhn is something the paradigm cannot make fit. A finding that "should not" happen if the textbook is true. Normal science pushes it into the box or calls it noise. When anomalies pile up, the crisis comes.

In our context, **the paradigm** is as follows.

A human sees, feels and clicks. Brand and reputation are shaped in the middle. AIDA and Kotler's funnel are the map. The brand premium is a lasting moat.

The anomalies are everything that happens as if that map no longer applies. And now they are starting to pile up. Or so we believe.

Anomalies in the buying process with digital agents vs humans

1. People buy without having seen the campaign.
2. The search happens in a conversation, not in a search field you can buy.
3. The evaluation is a table, not a feeling.

4. Checkout happens with a single-use card in an agent, not on your landing page.
5. Loyalty shows up as policy ("always this", "never that"), not as "brand love".
6. Retargeting pools fill up with traffic that is not human.

That "should" not happen if AIDA is true. Yet it does. Meta Muse books travel. Google AI Mode puts the hotel in the conversation. The finger is gone. The word is in control. Your voice and mine, talking to the digital agent.

Anomalies in brand and reputation

1. The campaign wins the jury and loses the sale.
2. Awareness is high, choice is low, because the choice no longer sits in the head that saw the film.
3. Purpose and iconic images increase pressure in the wrong place (Lofoten in July), while the strategy wants spread to the whole country, all year round
4. The corpus "knows" that Norway is expensive and full. The film about silence does not change that, because the corpus rarely watches films. The brand exists in the corpus.
5. The CMO cannot test a message without the test becoming politics; the room for manoeuvre is used up.

The paradigm says more signal gives more capital. The anomaly is that more signal gives lock-in.

Anomalies in Norwegian travel

1. Record guest nights and, at the same time, queues, wear and tear and commission to OTAs.
2. The destination film is visible. The room is invisible to the agent because the catalogue is missing.

3. The guest wants to “see Norway”. The agent chooses Iceland or the same five icons.
4. The goal is more nights across the whole country all year round; the graph sends more bodies to Preikestolen in week 29.

Visit Norway can say “the whole country, all year round”. If the corpus is nevertheless Preikestolen, Lofoten and NOK 1,900 for a room in July, that is what the agent has to rank on. Until the catalogue (what you sell, structured) and the actual tourists and trips rewrite the corpus.

The anomalies are not decoration. They are the evidence that we are in Kuhn’s crisis, not yet in a new normal science. The CMO handbook and the destination budget still treat them as exceptions: “e-commerce”, “an OTA problem”, “an AI thing”.

Our point is the opposite. The exception is becoming the purchase. When it is expected that the agent carries out the middle phase, the anomaly is over. And the paradigm has shifted. Until then, the job is to name what does not fit in the box, before the spreadsheet manages to call it noise.

The anomalies piled up in our analysis. Other theories can shed light on the digital agents’ triumphal march from other perspectives.

Schumpeter reminded us that capitalism revolutionizes the structure from within, “incessantly destroying the old one, incessantly creating a new one”. What is being destroyed here is not commerce. It is the combination of brand plus human attention plus the middle phase of the funnel. **Christensen** would have said that the job “get the purchase done” is being hired anew. **Kuhn** would have said that the CMO handbook is still normal science. That is, one forces new phenomena into an old box, and what does not fit is often not seen.

At the same time, something is happening that the technology explanation alone does not capture. Many companies have spent years charging their brand with signals the field rewards. Purpose, values campaigns, stakeholder language, mimetic “best practice”. **DiMaggio and Powell** named the paradox. **Rational actors make organizations increasingly similar as they try to change them.** The analogy to Ward Cunningham’s technical debt is deliberate. A little debt gives speed. Unpaid

debt stiffens the architecture. Reputation and marketing choices can provide legitimacy now and reduce room for manoeuvre later. Interest is paid as self-censorship, a lost core base and signals an agent cannot use. Reputational lock-in is the popular label for one visible form of interest. It is not the law. It is a special case of a broader balance sheet item.

This Disruptive Perspectives note therefore stands at the intersection of two movements that are rarely considered together. One is technological and disruptive, as the agent becomes the buyer. The other is institutional and self-imposed, as the company dares less and less to be a product. *The question is not whether brands "die". The question is what kind of brand survives when the one who pays no longer sits in the same room as the one who judges the reputation.*

This gives seven analytical questions. They are not decoration. They are the common thread of the introduction, because each opens a problem that cannot be settled with one discipline or perspective alone. Here follow seven sources of reflection for those who want them.

1. If the agent is the buyer, what is a brand worth?

The question looks naive. Brands have been worth something for as long as there has been uncertainty and social meaning. Damodaran's test is nevertheless merciless: what happens to the value tomorrow if the brand name is removed, and if the eye is removed while the catalogue remains? A brand that only lives as an idea in a field is not capital. It is a loan against a subject who may already have delegated the choice.

2. Which part of today's marketing budget is investment, and which part is interest on reputational debt?

The budget is presented as growth. Parts of it are maintenance of earlier signals. The cost of not contradicting yourself, of keeping the jury alive, of avoiding internal conflict. Separating investment from interest is impossible without a theory of lock-in. That is why institutional theory must enter the marketing accounts, not just sociology.

3. Which companies have a high brand premium and low machine-readable differentiation – and are therefore most exposed?

This is where Porter meets the protocol. The premium in the multiple is often priced as an eternal moat. If the differentiation cannot be coded as attributes, returns, inventory and constraints, the premium is a bet against Muse, Gemini and the next pair of glasses. The list of the exposed is not "everyone with a logo". It is those where the logo is the advantage.

4. Is reputational lock-in a special case of reputational debt, or a media simplification?

The slogan is too sharp to be a law, and too accurate to be dismissed. Nike, Bud Light and Target show a break between the *job-to-be-done* and the field signal. The literature disagrees about consistent stock market punishment. If the question is only posed as a culture war, the mechanism disappears. If it is never posed, the most visible interest item disappears.

5. Who owns the mandate in five years: the operating system, the glasses, the payment or the agent?

This is Metcalfe translated into power. Whoever owns the default (history, cards, vetoes, field of view) owns the funnel. The brand can become a row. The platform can become the principal's real counterparty. Without this question, "omnichannel" becomes a comfort and not a diagnosis.

6. When the room for manoeuvre has been lost by your own doing, who really owns the brand – the communications field, the owners, or the principal who gives the agent its mandate?

The question forces out a conflict of interest that the annual report rarely writes about. The CMO optimizes towards isomorphism and a career in the field. The owners optimize towards ROIC and optionality. The principal optimizes towards an outcome. Three principal–agent relationships, not one. If the field de facto owns the brand, the reputational debt is not an error in execution. It is a form of governance. Then "repositioning" is not a campaign. It is a coup against an internal coalition.

7. What distinguishes brand equity from brand lock-in in a valuation – and how is a paradigm shift priced before it has become "expected"?

Buffett asked why the castle will still be standing in five, ten, twenty years. Kuhn reminds us that the castle in the spreadsheet stands longer than the castle in the world, because normal science calls the anomaly noise. The investor who waits until agent purchasing is "consensus" pays for the insight after it has been priced in. The capital/lock-in distinction is therefore not semantics. It is the difference between discounting an asset and overlooking a loan.

The purpose of this note is to define key concepts, show the connections between them, and apply those connections to marketing in general and the buying process in particular.

The contribution is a working concept, reputational or institutional debt, and a model of what happens when that debt meets an agentic funnel. Theoretically, we draw on Schumpeter, Christensen, Kuhn, Porter, Metcalfe, Kim and Mauborgne, DiMaggio and Powell, Stigler's capture and Cunningham's debt metaphor. Those who have read earlier notes and the book Postkort fra fremtiden (Postcards from the Future) will recognize our theoretical anchors. When you analyze the future, you meet a world without empirical evidence. That means everything is a mental and theoretical construction. In that sense, we are not alone.

The scope is deliberately limited. This note is not a campaign evaluation, not an ESG debate, nor a prediction of one winning platform. It asks what room for manoeuvre remains when the brand neither dares to speak freely nor is allowed to speak to the

one who pays anymore. That combination can be disruptive for well-established business models when the four horsemen ride into their

4.0 Marketing as institutional debt

The issue is that classic marketing rests on a tacit assumption that value is created by shaping a human's preference under uncertainty. The brand reduces search costs, creates trust and provides identity. Advertising buys attention. Reputation is a buffer against doubt. The whole apparatus (agency, CMO, media buying, purpose platform, crisis management) is built for a subject who sees, feels and clicks.

That assumption is becoming history. In Postkort fra fremtiden (Postcards from the Future) we describe digital agents and voice technology as two of four horsemen riding into business. The agents take on cognitive tasks, and language becomes the bridge between human and machine.

Meta Muse, launched on 8 September 2026, is no longer a postcard. The agent opens a browser, fills in forms, negotiates and checks out with Stripe Link. It asks before spending money, but it gets the job done. The glasses make the command situated in the room.

That changes the question marketing must answer. It is no longer "how do we get the human to choose us?", but "how does the brand survive when the one who chooses neither gets bored in a queue, watches the 50 km race at Holmenkollen, nor needs to feel like a good person at the checkout?"

This chapter argues that large parts of today's reputation and marketing strategy are best understood as institutional debt: choices that provided legitimacy and speed in one regime, but constrain the room for manoeuvre in the next. The analogy to technical debt is deliberate. Ward Cunningham wrote in 1992:

«Shipping first time code is like going into debt. A little debt speeds development so long as it is paid back promptly with a rewrite. The danger occurs when the debt is

not repaid. Every minute spent on not-quite-right code counts as interest on that debt.»

Replace "code" with "brand signal", and "rewrite" with "repositioning". Then you have the thesis of this chapter.

4.1 From brand equity to brand lock-in

Porter taught us that differentiation is only strategy if it creates willingness to pay or switching costs. Brand equity in the classic sense (awareness, associations, perceived quality, loyalty) can do exactly that. "Just do it" was not an attitude. It was a compression of the job Nike was hired to do: performance, victory, action without excuses.

Clayton Christensen moves the focus from who the customer is to which job the customer hires the product to do:

«When we buy a product, we essentially 'hire' something to get a job done. If it does the job well, when we are confronted with the same job, we hire that same product again. And if the product does a crummy job, we 'fire' it.»

As long as the buyer is human, the brand can carry two jobs at once: the functional one (shoes that last and give grip) and the social one (a signal of who I am). Institutional brand building (purpose, values campaigns, stakeholder narratives) lives almost exclusively in the second job. It can be profitable. It can also become lock-in.

Lock-in arises when the signals that were supposed to increase capital instead increase internal switching costs. The organization can no longer speak precisely to the core base without breaking an earlier promise to the field. It cannot test messages without the test becoming politics. It cannot lower prices, change the range or switch ambassadors without it being read as a moral fall. The room for manoeuvre shrinks by its own doing.

Warren Buffett expressed the old reputation logic by saying that it takes twenty years to build a reputation and five minutes to ruin it, and that you can afford to lose money, but not "even a shred of reputation". The point is correct about fragility. It is

incomplete about ownership. In the agent economy, it is no longer just five human minutes that can tear down a reputation. It is also one update to the agent's policy, one bad return statistic in the training data, and one brand that the agent has learned to treat as noise.

Schumpeter reminds us that this is not a communications problem, but a fundamental feature of capitalism:

«This process of industrial mutation [...] incessantly revolutionizes the economic structure from within, incessantly destroying the old one, incessantly creating a new one. This process of Creative Destruction is the essential fact about capitalism.»

What is being destroyed here is not just a channel. It is the attention economy as a revenue model for the brand.

4.2 The three isomorphisms in the communications department

Why do rational companies take on such debt? Institutional theory provides the mechanism. DiMaggio and Powell, mentioned in chapter 2.1, observed the paradox as early as 1983:

«*Once a set of organizations emerges as a field, a paradox arises: rational actors make their organizations increasingly similar as they try to change them.*»

The similarity is produced by three isomorphisms. All three are visible in modern brand and reputation management.

Coercive isomorphism. Reporting requirements, public procurement rules, ESG indices, advertising law, platform rules and "brand safety" lists force a common language. The company does not signal primarily to the customer, but to the gatekeepers who allocate capital, shelf space and the licence to be visible.

Mimetic isomorphism. Under uncertainty, you copy what looks legitimate. When one player runs a Pride collection, a purpose film or a "values-led" Super Bowl spot, the

absence of the same becomes a deviation. The uncertainty is real: no CMO can prove the exact return on reputation. That is why the form is copied.

Normative isomorphism. Communications education, agencies, juries, awards and trade media reward a particular craft. The campaign that wins the Gullblyanten award is not necessarily the campaign that wins at the till. The individual's career is optimized towards recognition in the field.

The result is an iron cage of best practice. Weber described the cage of rationality, DiMaggio and Powell moved the engine from market competition to the state and the professions. In marketing, the cages are made of tone-of-voice guides, stakeholder matrices and an unspoken rule that the brand must never be caught being just a product.

Regulatory capture reinforces the cage. When industry norms and regulation are written by incumbents and their stakeholder machinery, yesterday's model of visible value positioning, human attention and a controlled narrative is protected. What is not protected is the ability to be chosen by an agent that does not sit on the jury.

4.3 Digital agents as a new reputation and marketing surface

Digital agents do not just change who buys. They change where reputation lives.

First, the brand is compressed. Ten years of storytelling must pass through a narrow pipe: a few hundred characters in an agent summary, a row in a comparison, a yes/no in a constraint. Stellagent and similar analyses of Meta's agent push point to exactly this: when the agent summarizes the brand for the user, only what can be coded as attributes, reliability and match against the mandate survives.

Second, discovery moves out of the funnel that marketing owns. Muse can retrieve a saved recipe reel on Instagram, create a shopping list and place the order. Shopify stores in the US were automatically exposed in Muse unless they opted out. Checkout happens with single-use cards. The platform that built the modern advertising machine is now building a way around it.

Third, reputation becomes a data problem. The agent "knows" the brand through catalogue data, reviews, return rates, delivery accuracy, price deviations, earlier mandates and what the language models have picked up from the open internet. A campaign the field loved can become noise or a negative signal in the corpus. A boring, predictable supplier can become the default.

Fourth, a measurement break occurs. Agencies already see retargeting pools filling up with non-human traffic. The agent's browser is designed to resemble a human in a form. The old reputation currency (views, engagement, brand lift in tracking surveys) loses its connection to the one who actually pays.

Fifth, the agent gets its own reputational risks, both for the brand and for the platform. Muse promises that conversations and data in the agent's virtual machine are not shared with Meta's advertising systems. That is in itself a reputational move, giving trust to the proxy. At the same time, it is a strategic break. Whoever owns the mandate owns the relationship. Whoever owns the relationship has less need to buy attention.

In earlier notes, we have argued that the interface is what is decisive:

"We are entering the age of the voice command, where both our physical and digital worlds will be controlled by your words to humanoids, AI agents and cars."

A concrete **reputation example** is that the user can give the agent vetoes ("do not buy from companies with poor working conditions", "always brand X for running shoes", "avoid Y after that campaign"). What used to be a feeling at the checkout becomes policy. Policy is harder to campaign your way out of than a bad quarter in the brand tracker.

Another example is crisis communication. The classic exercise is to own the narrative in the press in the first hours. Against an agent, the timeline is different. Wrong prices, failing stock status, poor returns handling and inconsistent product copy are the crisis. The press release does not reach into the virtual machine that has already chosen another supplier.

A third is the "AI-washed" brand. Companies themselves use agents to produce content, community replies and copy at industrial scale. That increases the volume of

signals the field recognizes as legitimate, and lowers the density of signals a purchasing agent can use. You pay interest twice, more noise out, less trust in.

4.4 The interest on reputational debt

Technical debt has well-known interest items such as inertia, defects and the ability to change. Reputational debt has its own. Here we go through some of them.

Lost precision. When the brand means “victory, sustainability, inclusion, innovation, responsibility and belonging” all at once, it means nothing to an agent that has to rank two SKUs.

Lost experimentation. A/B testing of messages becomes internal politics. In software, whatever makes change expensive is refactored. In brands, change is avoided because the last signal has been made sacred.

Lost core base. Christensen would have said that you fire the customer who hired you for one job, because you are chasing another customer’s social job. The core base has lower switching costs than the field believes. The agent has close to zero.

Lost agent compatibility. Signals that cannot be expressed as quality, price, delivery time, durability, returns and constraints fall out of the utility function.

Lost optionality. This is the decisive interest. The debt is not felt as long as the paradigm stands. It is felt when you suddenly have to speak differently (to a new buyer, in a new channel, after a shift in sentiment) and discover that you have used up the sentences you are allowed to say.

Cunningham’s warning was not that debt is immoral. A small, deliberate debt gives speed. The danger is unpaid debt that stiffens the architecture. Likewise, a temporary reputational position can be rational (talent, licence, index, political risk). It becomes dangerous when it cannot be refinanced against the one who actually pays.

4.5 Isomorphism – a reputational risk?

Nike's fall is analytically useful because it points to a break between the brand's job and the field signal, not because the slogan is a law of nature. David Sacks of the All-In podcast argues that Nike stood for sport, performance and victory ("Isn't Nike the goddess of victory?") and that campaigns without that anchoring were "breathtakingly stupid" precisely as marketing. He draws the line to Dylan Mulvaney and Bud Light. The same type of break between the core job and the institutional signal.

The All-In conversation also includes other causes. A DTC strategy that alienated retail, a reorganization away from sports divisions, lost shelf space to Hoka and On, a slump in China. That is accurate. Reputational debt is rarely the only cause. It is an amplifier: it makes it more expensive to admit mistakes and more expensive to return to the job the brand was actually hired to do.

Bud Light and Target show the same mechanism in a purer form. Mimetic isomorphism ("this is what responsible brands do now") meets a core base that had not hired the brand for that job. The literature disagrees on how consistently reputational lock-in shows up in returns. That is not the point of this chapter. The point is that such campaigns are a visible, politicized variant of a broader balance sheet item. Signals bought for legitimacy in the field, which later limit who you can sell to.

Against the agent, the special case becomes general. The agent has no shame, no jury and no LinkedIn feed. It has goals and constraints. A brand that primarily exists as a moral idea has little to offer beyond whatever the user may have coded in as a veto. Then the brand is no longer capital. It is an if statement.

The matrix crosses what the brand primarily signals with who interprets the signal. It is the chapter's compressed model.

Postcards From The Future

Brand and reputation

INTERPRETATION		Job to be done (quality, price, delivery, performance, predictability)	SIGNAL Institutional identity (purpose, politics, field norms, the jury)
	Human attention	**A. Brand equity** Classic, bankable differentiation. Nike "Just do it" / Jordan. Costco. Toyota reliability, Miele. Attention reinforces the job. Low institutional debt, as long as awareness is not confused with meaning.	**B. Reputational debt building up** Field legitimacy, uncertain effect on sales. Purpose campaigns, ESG films, "values-led", parts of Nike, Bud Light, Target Pride collection. High visibility, high internal switching costs. Interest is felt through boycotts, talent flight or not daring to turn around.
	Digital agent with mandate	**C. Agent capital** (blue ocean for the boring) Machine-readable job. Default in the utility function. Structured catalogue, API, returns, delivery accuracy, Stripe/Link-compatible checkout, Shopify feed into Muse, "always this SKU". The Costco logic coded as policy	**D. Double debt** Brands that have used up their sentences, with a weak operational core and a heavy identity load. Campaigns that are neither a constraint the customer wants ("avoid substance X") nor a job the agent can rank. Room for manoeuvre is smallest here. Refactoring is expensive

Read the matrix like this: the movement the market is forcing is from A towards C. The movement the field has rewarded is from A towards B. The trap is from B to D, when the agent takes over the funnel before the company has paid down its signal debt.

Two clarifications. First, identity signals can survive in box C if they are coded as the customer's own mandate ("buy second-hand first", "avoid this supplier"). Then it is no longer the brand's theatre, it is the user's constraint. Second, box A can still be valuable where the purchase remains human and social. Luxury, status, experience. But the share of such purchases falls wherever our horsemen gain a foothold.

Marketing and reputation strategy are not the opposite of technical debt. They are the same class of phenomenon in another layer of the company, as short-term legitimacy and speed, bought with an architecture that makes the next move more expensive.

DiMaggio and Powell explain why the debt is taken on. Cunningham explains why it must be repaid. Christensen explains which job actually earns repeat purchases. Schumpeter explains that the old combination (brand plus human attention) has no claim to eternal life. We point to the horsemen who are already in the room. Muse is one of the postcards.

The theses carried forward into chapter 5, on **the buying process**, are therefore three:

1. The more the brand is loaded with signals that only a human in a field can reward, the higher the institutional debt.
2. Digital agents do not refinance that debt with applause. They ignore it, or they turn it into a veto.
3. The self-imposed loss of room for manoeuvre (that the company "cannot say it anymore") is not culture. It is a balance sheet item. It falls due when the agent, not you, carries out the purchase.

The next chapter moves the subject in the funnel, from AIDA to the proxy mandate.

5.0 The buying process when the agent is the subject

As long as Kotler's five stages and AIDA describe reality, marketing has a home. There is a human who has to discover a need, search, evaluate, choose and live with the choice. There, attention can be bought, desire awakened and loyalty cultivated. The whole discipline is built around that subject, including the part of the discipline that in chapter 1 was diagnosed as isomorphism. The purpose film only has meaning if someone watches it. The jury only has power if the middle phase is still human.

That subject is being delegated. Not the market as such, and not the need, but the execution of the journey. The principal (you and I) sets goals, budget and veto. The digital agent searches, negotiates, checks out and learns.

Commerce does not collapse. The funnel collapses as a map of a human. The need stage becomes a mandate. Search becomes a graph. Evaluation becomes a utility function. The checkout becomes infrastructure. Loyalty becomes policy. What in chapter A looked like brand equity (stories, identity, field signals) meets a buyer without shame, without a jury and without a LinkedIn feed.

The question that opens the chapter is the first analytical question from the introduction, now posed operationally. Because if the agent is the buyer, what is a brand worth, and who is left in the funnel when you have said the word and walked away?

5.1 The classic funnel and its hidden subject

The buying process is marketing's most durable map. In Kotler's five-stage model, the consumer goes through problem recognition, information search, evaluation of alternatives, purchase decision and post-purchase behaviour. The point of the model, as Kotler himself stresses, is that this is a journey, not a moment. And that routine purchases can skip stages, while high involvement forces all of them.

Next to it lies AIDA, the oldest persuasion funnel in the discipline: Attention, Interest, Desire, Action. Whether its origin is attributed to E. St. Elmo Lewis or later refinements, the logic is the same. First you must catch an eye. Then hold it, awaken desire, and then get an action.

Both maps have a hidden subject. It is a human with limited attention, social contagion, habit and shame. That is why advertising, shelf space, packaging, reviews, "unboxing" and brand films have been rational investments. They target the stages where a human can be derailed.

Christensen moves the question from stage to job:

«When we buy a product, we essentially 'hire' something to get a job done»

In the classic funnel, the human hires both the product and the marketing. The marketing is hired to reduce uncertainty, give language to a need and legitimize the choice to others. When the job "complete the purchase" moves to an agent, the second contract is terminated.

In another note, we have described Audun's best use case:

"When I ask the digital agent to find the best and cheapest trip to Rome with my wife. Where I used to spend half an hour with fingers and keyboards, the digital agents will now search, find and get back to me within a few seconds."

What disappears in those seconds is not just time. It is the whole human middle of the funnel.

5.2 What actually collapses

McKinsey calls the shift "agentic commerce". Agents that anticipate needs, navigate alternatives, negotiate and execute, in line with human intention, but through multi-step chains of action. They estimate that this could orchestrate up to USD 1 trillion in US B2C commerce and 3–5 trillion globally by 2030. Their point is not the forecast's decimals, but the nature of the break: "*This isn't just an evolution of e-commerce. It's a rethinking of shopping itself*».

Three things collapse at the same time.

Attention as the entry ticket. AIDA assumes that someone must see you before anyone can want you. The agent sees a catalogue lookup, an API and a constraint. Display, influencers and brand films do not reach into the virtual machine unless they have already been distilled into data.

Evaluation as theatre. The human evaluates with stories, status and "it feels right". The agent evaluates with weights. Storytelling only survives if it can be coded as an attribute, reputation in the corpus or a veto the user has given.

Checkout as a brand moment. The payment page was the last chance to upsell, show trust, rescue a drop-off. Muse checks out with Stripe Link and single-use cards. Google's Universal Commerce Protocol makes the checkout a common language

between agent, commerce platform and wallet. Microsoft, OpenAI and Perplexity are building parallel tracks. The checkout is becoming a protocol, not an experience.

Kuhn would have called these anomalies piling up inside normal science. The marketer keeps optimizing CTR while the purchase happens in another system. *Christensen* would have said that the job has moved. *Schumpeter* would have said that the old combination (attention plus persuasion plus a human click) is being destroyed from within.

5.3 The digital agent's funnel

The new journey also has stages. They are just split between two actors.

Postcards From The Future

The digital agent's buying process (funnel)

Stage	What happens	Who acts	What is replaced
1. Mandate	Goals, budget, brand veto, ethics, brand preferences, approval threshold	The human, once or rarely	Need triggers in advertising, "problem recognition" as a campaign job
2. Observation	Calendar, health, past buys, saved reels, glasses images, stock in the cupboard	Agent + sensors + platform history	Market research and "insight" that the company owns
3. Search	Cross-store, cross-protocol, negotiation	The agent	SEO, SEM, feed ads, shelf space
4. Evaluation	Weights vs constraints, price, TCO, returns, delivery, reputation in data	The agent	Consideration set shaped by brand and social proof
5. Approval	"Ask above NOK 500", "always milk", "never brand Y"	The human only on exceptions	Final persuasion on the product page
6. Execution	Basket, single-use card, UCP/AP2 mandate, shipping	Agent + wallet + protocol	Branded checkout, the brand moment
7. Learning	Outcome written into the policy	The agent, with or without brief feedback	Loyalty programme, CRM, "brand love"

The human is the principal. The agent is an agent in the economic sense: a proxy with limited discretion. Meta Muse is built this way. Meta says explicitly that the product *«doesn't just answer questions, it actually does the work»,* and that it comes back «when it needs approval, like before it sends an email or makes a purchase».

That is a different subject from Kotler's consumer. The consumer is the funnel. The principal sets up the funnel and leaves it.

Two consequences follow immediately:

First, **low-involvement purchases**, such as milk, bin bags, toilet paper and standard electronics, become the agent's home ground. Kotler said that such purchases skip search and evaluation. Now they skip the human.

Second, **high-involvement purchases** are split. The mandate ("find the best trip to Rome under NOK 15,000, direct flight, hotel near the centre, no chains we hated last time") is high involvement. The execution is low. The brand that used to live in the dream of Rome meets a procurement function.

5.4 Muse, glasses and the protocols as a concrete postcard

In the Disruptive Perspectives notes and in the book, we draw four innovation platforms that we often call our four horsemen. About the digital agents we say:

"When the 'Battle of the Metaverse' starts sometime in 2026 or 2027, it is the glasses on the tip of your nose, together with the voice-controlled digital agent, that will fight the fingers and the iPhone's dance between back pocket and ear.»

Muse, launched in the US on 8 September 2026, is the horseman's first mass-market clearance. The agent runs on a virtual machine (a VM) in Meta's cloud, with its own Chromium browser. It can connect email, calendar, health, Instagram and Facebook, build a shopping list from saved reels, negotiate and pay. Stripe Link issues single-use cards. Shop Pay and 1Password are coming. Glasses have been announced as the next surface.

Around Muse, a protocol layer is being built that makes this repeatable across platforms. Google UCP describes commerce as shared primitives between surface, shop and payment. AP2, donated to the FIDO Alliance, answers a different question: can you prove that the human has given the agent permission to use exactly this money, with exactly this seller, for exactly this basket? Without that proof, agent purchasing is either a toy or a legal risk. With that proof, it is infrastructure.

Metcalfe belongs here. The value of Muse is not the chat. It is the number of connected services, identities, cards and shops. Whoever first becomes the default for

the mandate gets super-linear returns. **Blue ocean** is not a new slogan. It is becoming the row the agent does not even compare away.

At the same time, Muse tells us something about reputation from chapter 4. Meta promises that conversations and content in the virtual machine do not go into the advertising systems. That is trust in the proxy. It is also a tacit admission: whoever owns the mandate no longer needs to buy as much attention. The platform unbundles the relationship from the advertising.

5.5 Who wins in the agent's evaluation?

The agent has no jury. It has a utility function. In the first generation it will typically weight:

- price and total cost of ownership, not just the shelf price
- delivery accuracy and return friction
- stock availability right now
- structured data and APIs, not landing-page prose
- history of complaints and support
- brand policy the user has written themselves
- reputation that exists in data and the corpus, not in film
- payment and protocol compatibility (UCP, Link, Shop Pay)

That is why three archetypes win.

The default. The one that sits in the mandate ("always this milk", "always this insurance company"). That is Metcalfe + habit, coded as a rule.

The boring row. Predictable quality, a clean catalogue, low friction. The Costco logic without the warehouse experience. The job gets done, the product is hired again.

The constraint owner. The one that becomes the user's own veto ("no fast fashion", "only this running shoe", "avoid substance X"). Here identity can survive, but only as the customer's policy, not as the brand's theatre..

5.6 Implications for marketing in general

Three survival strategies remain.

1. Become the default in the agent's graph. Integrate catalogue, checkout and policy. Be where Muse, Gemini, Copilot and the next pair of glasses look first. This is a platform game. It requires humility. You no longer own the entrance.
2. Become the reliable row. Operations beat narrative. Inventory, returns, price discipline, product data. This is the antithesis of the CMO field's isomorphism. It looks boring to the jury and expensive in the ERP. It is nevertheless the job the agent hires.
3. Become a mandate, not a brand. Own the category in the user's rules. It is the only form of "brand love" that survives delegation. Loyalty becomes configuration.

Purpose only survives as a programmable constraint the customer actually wants. "Avoid this chemical" is a mandate. "We believe in a better world" is a signal to the field. The agent tells the two apart effortlessly.

Measurement must be rewritten. Views, reach and brand lift in surveys describe a subject who is less and less often in the room. New questions: "Do we make it into the consideration set the agent builds? Do we survive a cross-market price search? Are we protocol compatible? How often are we the default? How often are we the veto?"

And institutional debt gets a new interest charge. The more the communications department has optimized for human recognition in stages 2–4, the emptier the toolbox when those stages are automated. You are left with a corps that can make films for an eye that no longer exists.

5.7 When machines are allowed to pay

Digital agents do not primarily change how a payment technically goes through. Visa, Mastercard, banks and acquirers can still sit under the bonnet much as before. What changes is who is allowed to initiate the payment. In today's e-commerce, buyer and payer are usually the same person. You find the product, consider the alternatives, choose the shop, approve the purchase and pay. The whole buying process sits in one head and happens in front of one screen. With digital agents, these roles can be separated from each other. You can ask an agent to find the best flight to London under NOK 4,000, and let it search, compare departure times, read terms and choose an option. The interesting question arises when it reaches the last step. Does it have to bring you back to pay, or has it already been authorized to do so itself?

Principal–agent theory offers a useful language for this. The principal owns the money and the risk, while the agent acts on behalf of the principal within an agreed framework. This is not new in itself. Companies give employees purchasing authority, parents let children use the family card, and a lawyer can act on behalf of a client. The difference is that the agent can now be software. When a digital agent gets access to the browser, a wallet and the ability to complete a purchase, the mandate must be built into the system itself. The software must know what it may buy, how much it may spend and when it must ask the human. Payment is thus split into layers that used to be tightly connected. First comes the intention, that is, what the user wants to achieve. Then comes the mandate, which determines how far the agent can go on its own. Then comes the trade itself, with the choice of product, shop and terms, before the payment finally goes through the bank, the card network or another payment rail.

Traditional payment systems are very good at answering whether a transaction can be completed. Agentic commerce adds a new question on top of this. Was whoever initiated the transaction actually allowed to do so? This is where the mandate becomes interesting as a market in its own right. A simple analogy is buying a house. The bank can make sure the money arrives and that settlement is completed, but if another person is to buy the house on your behalf, they need a power of attorney stating what they can do. Digital agents need something similar. The difference is that

this mandate does not necessarily sit in a signed document, but can sit in code. The agent may, for example, be allowed to spend up to NOK 5,000 on flights, but have to ask if the price goes higher. It may buy groceries from certain shops, but not electronics. The mandate thus becomes a property of the system, and whoever controls this mandate gains a far more important position in the buying process than before.

The payment itself can still look quite familiar. Nor does the agent need access to the actual card number. One possible model is that the user connects the agent to a digital wallet. When the agent wants to buy something, it sends a request with information about the shop, amount and purpose. The user approves the purchase, and the wallet creates a virtual card or payment token that the agent can use. The card can be limited to one purchase, a specific amount or a specific shop, and stop working afterwards. From the shop's side, this can still look like a perfectly ordinary card transaction. A card number comes in, the bank approves the payment and the card network moves the money. But the user experience is different. The customer may never have opened the online shop, never seen the payment page and never chosen which retailer would get the order. The agent found the product, chose the shop and filled in the information. The human just said yes.

Technically, this is a continuation of tokenization and virtual cards. The conceptual shift therefore does not necessarily lie in the payment rail, but in who stands at the checkout. The bank can still own the financing and the card network can still move the money, but the screen where the decision is made can be owned by someone else. This is also where the first clear conflicts are starting to appear. In April 2026, Stripe Link opened up for agent-based payments built on Stripe Issuing, where an agent can ask for access to the user's wallet, send a request to spend money and, after approval, receive a virtual card or payment token it can use in the transaction. In September, Meta Muse became the first agent covered by Link's purchase protection on eligible purchases. Muse operates in its own secure virtual machine, shows the user what it has done and is not supposed to get access to the user's actual card number.

Other agents draw the line for the mandate differently. Instinct has terms that allow the service to enter into agreements that bind the user, while Grok Bot more often hands payment and two-factor authentication back to the human. The difference between them is therefore less about whether money can be moved, and more about how much of the decision is allowed to sit with the machine. We see the same divide among the commerce platforms. On 20 and 21 September 2026, Amazon shut Muse out of its marketplace. The problem was not that card payment stopped working, but that an external agent was acting on behalf of Amazon's customers without Amazon itself controlling that relationship. Shopify chose the opposite strategy and opened its catalogue and checkout to Muse. Two major players thus ended up on opposite sides of the same question: who should own the customer when the agent both finds the product and brings the payment?

This is also why agentic commerce may become more than a new layer on top of today's checkout. If the customer starts with an agent, the agent can choose which shop gets the order. The shop can still own the inventory, the delivery and the settlement, but lose the moment of decision itself. Amazon has said that its own shopping assistant has lifted conversion significantly and contributed large amounts of incremental sales inside Amazon's own ecosystem, while Shopify in the second quarter of 2026 reported strong growth in both AI-driven traffic and orders. That points in the same direction. The agents are starting to influence real purchases, and control over the agent and the mandate then becomes more important.

For the banks, the picture is more complex. As long as the agent pays with a card issued by the bank, the bank can still earn money on the transaction. If the agents make commerce easier and increase purchase volumes, payment volumes may also grow. At the same time, the bank may lose something that in the long run is more important than the transaction itself, namely influence over the customer's choice. An agent instructed to buy as cheaply as possible has no emotional attachment to a particular card or payment brand. If one payment method gives a lower total price than another, the agent can choose the cheapest. That may be debit, account-to-account or other payment rails that gradually become available. A human customer

can be loyal to a credit card because of bonus points, habit or brand. A machine can be far more mechanical. It looks at terms and cost and chooses accordingly.

The same applies to credit. If the agent is told to minimize financing costs, it can actively avoid expensive credit. Parts of the economics that today sit with the card issuer may therefore come under pressure. The bank can still move the money, but at the same time lose influence over how it is spent. It risks becoming invisible financing behind someone else's yes button. The money goes through the bank, but the choice happens elsewhere.

At the same time, there is a possible new role here that fits very well with what banks already do. If a machine is to be allowed to spend our money, someone must know who it is acting for and what limits it has. How much can it spend? What types of purchases can it make? When must the human step back in? What happens if the agent buys the wrong product or is compromised? How is the mandate revoked? These are questions close to the bank's existing role in identity, liability and risk management. KYC, *know your customer*, has long been about knowing who the customer is. In an agentic economy, a new question may be added: which agent has the customer allowed to act?

You could call it *know your agent*. The bank's opportunity is therefore perhaps not to build the best shopping agent itself, but to become the infrastructure that other agents are allowed to use. An approved agent can get access to a wallet with clear spending limits, purchase protection and rules set by the customer. The bank handles identity and liability, while the agent handles the purchase. Then the bank can still own an important part of the trust even if it does not own the conversation.

Imagine asking Muse to buy a new laptop. The agent finds the model, compares shops and discovers a discount at Elkjøp. It puts the item in the basket and asks whether you approve NOK 14,499. You press yes. A virtual card is created, the agent pays, the bank sees a card transaction and Elkjøp gets an order. But almost the entire buying process has happened somewhere else. You never visited the shop, never compared prices yourself and perhaps did not even choose which retailer would get the money. The most important decision was made before the card was ever charged.

That is why agentic commerce is first and foremost about the mandate. Mastercard executive Sherri Haymond put it aptly in September 2026 when she said that "Agentic commerce will only scale at the speed of trust". Trust is not primarily about whether the terminal works or whether the money arrives. It is about whether whoever initiated the purchase, human or machine, was actually allowed to.

6.0 The disruptive mechanism

First we gave the debt a name. Then we gave it a place to fall due. Now we ask what is left to do.

The answer is not a new campaign platform. The answer is a concept of room for manoeuvre. Not market share, not awareness, not the jury's favour, but the number of moves a company can actually make without the architecture breaking. Technical debt limits what the system can become. Institutional debt limits what the company dares to be. Agentic purchasing punishes both, because the new buyer refinances neither with applause nor with emotions.

The synthesis must hold several theories in the same grip without them becoming decoration. Schumpeter explains that the attention economy is being destroyed from within. Christensen explains that the job has moved. Kuhn explains why the CMO handbook still calls the anomaly noise. DiMaggio and Powell explain why "transformation" is so often more of the same. Stigler explains that regulation can buy time, not eternity. Porter and Metcalfe explain the new balance of power. Kim and Mauborgne point to new markets.

The introduction to the synthesis can be stated as one sentence, because it is the bridge and not the decoration. When the brand neither dares to speak freely nor is allowed to speak to the one who pays anymore, the question is not how to win back the eye. The question is which castle is still standing, and whether the road to it still runs through you.

6.1 Where the argument stands

The first chapters said that marketing and reputation can accumulate as institutional debt. Signals that provide legitimacy in the field, but bind what the company later dares and is able to be. Then we say that the debt falls due in the buying process, because the subject in the funnel moves. The human sets the mandate. The agent searches, evaluates, pays and learns.

This chapter brings the theories together into one grip and poses the operational question: what kind of room for manoeuvre does a company have left when it neither dares to speak freely nor is allowed to speak to the one who pays anymore?

The answer is not that brands die. The answer is that brands that have spent their optionality on the field's applause meet a market where applause is no longer currency.

Postcards From The Future

The digital agent's buying process (funnel)

Theory	What it explains here	What it does not explain alone
Schumpeter	The attention economy is destroyed from within. New combination: mandate + agent + protocol + wallet.	Why incumbents keep buying the old combination.
Christensen	The job "get the purchase done" is hired away from the brand film and into the agent. Repurchase is a new hire, not a feeling.	Why some fire the core job deliberately.
Kuhn	The CMO handbook is normal science. Falling CTR, agent traffic in retargeting and checkout without a landing page are anomalies against a paradigm that still measures the eye.	Why anomalies are ignored for so long.
Porter	Power moves to whoever owns mandate, data and checkout. Switching costs fall between brands, rise towards the platform	The internal lock-in that means you cannot reposition.
Metcalfe	The value sits in the graph of services, cards, catalogues and trust. Default beats campaign	The content of what becomes the default.
Blue ocean	The red ocean is the fight for the human feed. The blue ocean is to be chosen by a machine that does not see the ad	That the field punishes whoever leaves the red ocean early.
Institutional theory	The isomorphisms explain why everyone looks alike when they "renew themselves".	The technological compelling force that makes sameness expensive.
Regulatory capture	Rules, standards and "brand safety" can delay agent purchasing and protect yesterday's model	That the protocol is being built anyway (UCP, AP2, Link).
Technical / institutional debt	Shared form: speed now, rigidity later. Interest as lost optionality.	Which new job actually pays down the debt.

Schumpeter's formulation is the outer frame:

«This process of industrial mutation [...] incessantly revolutionizes the economic structure from within, incessantly destroying the old one, incessantly creating a new one.»

Kuhn explains why those who own the old structure do not see the mutation as a mutation. Normal science, he wrote, is the attempt to force nature into the preformed and relatively inflexible box the paradigm supplies. What does not fit in the box is often not seen at all.

Marketing's box is AIDA and brand equity. The anomalies are already here: agents that buy without watching the film, retargeting pools with non-human traffic, checkout as a protocol, brands that win the jury and lose the till. Kuhn again: a paradigm shift is complete when "the anomalous has become the expected". We are not there yet. We are in the crisis phase, where the CMO still reports brand lift while the principal gives Muse a budget.

DiMaggio and Powell close the internal side:

«Rational actors make their organizations increasingly similar as they try to change them.»

That is why "transformation" in the communications department is so often more of the same. You change *tone of voice,* not subject.

6.2 Self-imposed room for manoeuvre

Room for manoeuvre is not the same as market share. It is the number of moves the company can actually make without the architecture breaking, in code, in capital structure, in brand, in internal coalitions.

Technical debt reduces what the system can become. Cunningham's point was never that debt is a sin. A small, deliberate debt gives speed. The danger is unpaid debt that brings the organization to a halt.

Institutional debt reduces what the company dares to be. It is felt as sentences you "cannot say", segments you "cannot speak to", tests you "cannot run", and products you "cannot sell anymore" – not because demand is gone, but because the last signal has made the next signal expensive.

The self-imposed part is the point. The competitor did not silence you. The field did, and you paid with your own campaigns. Coercive isomorphism (index, procurement, supervision) explains part of it. Mimetic and normative isomorphism explain the rest. The individual CMO's career is optimized towards the jury. The owners' optionality pays the bill.

Reputational lock-in is the politicized label for one form of interest. The Nike case in Sacks is useful as a break between job (victory, performance) and field signal, not as a law. Bud Light and Target are siblings. The mechanism is broader. Any brand that loads up on identity that cannot be coded as the customer's mandate is building lock-in. With a human, the lock-in can still convert. With an agent, it rarely does.

Remember Buffett's warning about fragility. In the mandate economy, the timeline is different. Five minutes in the press do not own the corpus. A return rate, a broken delivery promise and a policy user who writes "never that brand again" do.

6.3 What can delay it - and what cannot stop it

Stigler wrote that regulation is, as a rule, acquired by the industry and designed and operated primarily for its benefit. That gives an honest forecast: incumbents will try to define agent purchasing as dangerous, irresponsible or "not real commerce". Advertising rules, platform liability, human-in-the-loop requirements, labelling of automated purchases, licensing of agents, all of this can buy time for the old funnel.

Capture explains delay. It does not explain permanence. The protocols are already being built. UCP as a common language for basket and checkout, AP2 as proof that the human has actually given a mandate, Stripe Link as a wallet for a machine. When the infrastructure exists, commerce finds its way. Schumpeter is hardier than Stigler here. The mutation comes from within, even when the regulator is standing in the doorway.

The same applies to the field's own capture of the marketing function. Industry awards and ESG language can keep the CMO in the cage for a few more years. They cannot force Muse to watch the film.

6.4 The competitive surface that remains

Kim and Mauborgne distinguished the red ocean (a known market, a bloody fight over the same demand) from the blue ocean, where demand is created and rivals are temporarily irrelevant. The mistake many will make now is to look for a blue ocean inside the feed. That is the reddest water there is.

The remaining surface is narrower and more operational than the brand discipline likes.

A place in the mandate. Not "top of mind" in a human, but a rule in a proxy. "Always this one." "Never that one." "Ask me above this amount." Metcalfe decides who gets to stand first in line when the rule is triggered.

A machine-readable job. Christensen without the theatre: predictable quality, price, inventory, returns, TCO. The boring row in the table. A blue ocean for those who can bear to switch off the TV spot.

Protocol and checkout. UCP, wallets, single-use cards, provable mandates. Whoever is not compatible does not exist.

Constraint as a product. Identity only survives where the customer wants to code it themselves. "Avoid substance X" is a market. "We believe in a better world" is a note to the jury.

Kim and Mauborgne's ERRC grid, translated:

1. Eliminate: attention as the main KPI, purpose that cannot be coded, campaigns that primarily pay the field.
2. Reduce: brand theatre in low-involvement categories, internal veto rights that stop pricing and range decisions.
3. Raise: catalogue quality, fulfilment, returns, protocol, the ability to be the default.

4. Create: products and guarantees formulated as rules an agent can keep, and proofs of trust a wallet can accept.

It is not a new vision. It is a value curve written for a different subject.

Porter belongs in the same section. The five forces do not disappear. They change their point of attack. The threat of substitutes is no longer "another brand on the same shelf". It is "an agent that switches shelves without telling you". Supplier power is Meta, Google, Apple, Stripe and whoever owns the glasses. Buyer power is the principal, but exercised through a proxy that does not get tired, is not flattered and does not become loyal because of a film.

6.5 What management and investors should actually do about this

The book Postkort fra fremtiden (Postcards from the Future) is written for those who want to see the shift before it is fully priced in. The synthesis is therefore also a checklist, not just a model.

Map the debt. Which signals have we given that limit the next move? Who are we afraid of disappointing? The customer, the employees, the press, the index, the jury? If the answer is not the principal, it is debt.

Separate capital from lock-in. Brand equity is the ability to charge more or be switched away from less by the one who buys. Brand lock-in is the ability to stop ourselves. The two sit in the same note in the annual report. They are not the same asset.

Build for stage 1 and stage 6. Mandate and execution. Everything in between is increasingly owned by others. That is where the voice command sits. You say what you want, the system does it.

Pay down what can be paid down. Cunningham's rewrite has an analogue: repositioning towards the job-to-be-done, cleaning up the corpus and catalogue,

removing signals only the field rewards. It is expensive. Unpaid, it is more expensive when the middle phase is automated.

Price in the intermediary. Multiples that rest on eternal ownership of the funnel are a bet against Muse, Gemini, Copilot and the next pair of glasses. Multiples that rest on being the boring, true row are a bet with them.

In many contexts, we have warned against linear maps in an exponential landscape. That is precise here. Institutional debt feels linear. One more campaign, one more policy. The maturity is non-linear. **It comes when enough principals have delegated enough of the middle phase that the brand premium no longer has a subject**.

6.6 Closing thesis

Technical debt limits what the system can become. Reputational debt limits what the company dares to be. Agentic purchasing punishes both, because the new buyer neither refinances the debt with applause nor refinances the brand with emotions.

Schumpeter destroys the attention market. Christensen moves the job. Kuhn turns the CMO handbook into normal science in crisis. DiMaggio and Powell explain why so many keep copying each other anyway. Stigler can buy time. Metcalfe decides who owns the default. Kim and Mauborgne point to the water that is actually blue: not a new story for a human, but a rule a machine can keep.

The postcard from the future, translated into this chapter, is short. You point. You say a word. Someone else completes the purchase. If your brand then only exists as an idea in a field, it was never capital. It was a loan. The loan falls due the moment the agent, not you, sits in the funnel.

7.0 Investment implications

Theory can call a brand capital or debt. The investor has to put numbers on the distinction. Because in a DCF, a brand is not a logo and not a jury. It is an assumption

of higher margins, longer growth and lower risk. Wrapped in a multiple that pretends the paradigm still stands.

Since the 1970s, the financial market has given companies with strong brands premium pricing and a lower risk assessment. We often say that in disruptive times "low-beta stocks become high-beta stocks and high beta becomes low beta". That is just another way of saying that large, well-established companies' perceived lasting competitive advantages can quickly be eroded when the extended buying process moves from human hands, feet and cognitive processes to a digital agent with your mandate.

In earlier Disruptive Perspectives notes and the book Postkort fra fremtiden (Postcards from the Future), we have written for those who want to see. Those who want to see the shift before it is fully priced in. This is one such note. Of course we may be wrong, but we believe that over the next few years many of the strange things and phenomena we have described and analyzed will become something more people, not fewer, will care about.

The subject in the funnel moves, and much of what is called brand building is interest on institutional debt. What remains is to translate the insight into moats, inputs and capital allocation. Otherwise the analysis becomes a note to the CMO. The book, and this text, is also a note to whoever owns the castle.

Buffett's castle is the chapter's working metaphor. A lasting moat is being the lowest-cost producer or a brand people pay extra for. The second moat assumes that someone sees the brand and chooses it despite equivalent alternatives. The agent sees a row. The principal may have given a veto. Then the moat has not necessarily been stormed. It has been drained. World Book had a brand. The job moved. In 2021 Nike was priced as if "Just do it" were a perpetual licence on margin. By September 2026 more than 200 billion is gone, and its place in the S&P 100 is lost. That is not proof of a single cause. It is an example of a *Roman candle:* a moat that looked eternal.

Damodaran's narrow test keeps the calculation in order. The power of a brand name is the ability to charge a higher price for a nearly identical product. The extension this

chapter needs is one more sentence: what happens to the margin if the evaluation is done by Muse, not by a human who has seen the film? The difference between brand equity and brand lock-in then stops being semantics. It becomes the difference between discounting an asset and overlooking a loan.

The chapter will therefore do three things. Separate premium, lock-in and agentic funnel risk in the valuation inputs. Use Nike as a priced anomaly without turning the slogan into an investment rule. And give a checklist before you pay for the castle. Who is the buyer in five years, how programmable is the job, is the brand a default or a veto, and how much of the "brand" is rented attention from the same platforms that are now building a way around the advertising paid to reach us humans.

The question that opens the chapter is used to set the course. What distinguishes brand equity from brand lock-in in a valuation? And how is a paradigm shift priced before Kuhn would have called the anomaly expected? If the castle is priced as if the road to it still runs through the old funnel, it is not the brand that is expensive. It is the story about it.

Chapter 6 established the mechanism. This chapter translates it into capital. For the investor, a brand is not a story. It is an assumption about future margin, growth and duration, wrapped in a multiple. When the subject in the buying funnel moves, the assumption changes. When reputation is debt, the duration changes.

7.1 A brand is a moat - until it dries up

Buffett has said what matters most to him when he looks:

«The most important thing [is] trying to find a business with a wide and long-lasting moat around it ... protecting a terrific economic castle with an honest lord in charge of the castle.»

And in the 2007 letter, a little sharper:

«A truly great business must have an enduring 'moat' that protects excellent returns on invested capital. The dynamics of capitalism guarantee that competitors will repeatedly assault any business 'castle' that is earning high returns. Therefore a

*formidable barrier such as a company's being the low-cost producer (GEICO, Costco) or possessing a powerful worldwide brand (Coca-Cola, Gillette, American Express) is essential for sustained success. Business history is filled with '**Roman Candles,**' companies whose moats proved illusory and were soon crossed.»*

Two moats, then. Lowest cost, or a brand people pay extra for. A brand moat assumes that someone sees the brand and chooses it despite equivalent alternatives. The agent sees a row. The principal may have given a veto. Then the moat has not been crossed by a competitor with a better film. It has been drained because the castle no longer lies on the road the purchase takes.

Buffett's own World Book example is the warning built into the method. In 1986 the encyclopedia had "a real moat". In 1995, with CD-ROM and the internet, it was "Berkshire's biggest problem". The brand stood. The job had moved.

That is Christensen in a portfolio. It is also Kuhn, where the paradigm "strong brand = lasting ROIC" survives longer in the spreadsheet than in the funnel.

7.2 Where the brand sits in the valuation

Damodaran refuses to let "brand" become a catch-all for every advantage. His narrow test:

«The power of a brand name is that it allows you to charge a higher price than your competition, for an identical or almost identical product. [...] The test of whether a brand name has value lies in a company's pricing power, and its effect on profit margins.»

He also asks the only question that matters for an investor:

«What will happen to this firm's value, if it lost its brand name tomorrow?»

In his model, brand names show up in almost every input. For example, higher volume and growth, higher margins, sometimes lower reinvestment and lower risk. Coca-Cola is the textbook case because the product is nearly identical to generic cola. Apple is harder, as brand, system, design and platform are intertwined. Nike sits

somewhere in between. The Swoosh is a premium. It is also confused with distribution, athletes, innovation and a DTC strategy that could in itself destroy the shelf.

This chapter therefore needs three distinctions before anyone adjusts the cost of capital.

Brand premium is the ability to charge more or sell more to the one who actually buys. Brand lock-in is the ability to stop the next move (chapter 4). Agentic funnel risk is the probability that the buyer stops being a human in the middle phase (chapter 5).

The first is an asset. The other two are debt and paradigm risk. In the accounts, they often sit in the same note as "brand". In a valuation, they must be separated.

Postcards From The Future

Cash flow adjustments in buying process 2.0

Input	If the brand is capital (box A/C in ch. 1)	If the brand is lock-in + attention (box B/D)
Margin	Premium withstands comparison	Premium erodes when the agent ranks on price/TCO
Growth	Default in the mandate, category ownership	Growth relies on bought attention
Growth period	Longer, if the job is codable	Shorter: the anomaly gets priced in
Reinvestment	Catalogue, fulfilment, protocol	Endless media and "brand building"
WACC / risk	Operational predictability	Sentiment, boycotts, corpus, platform
Terminal value	ROIC over WACC can last	Roman candle: a moat that looked eternal

7.3 Nike as a priced anomaly – and as a trap

In November 2021, Nike was worth around USD 264 billion. In September 2026, the company is at around 54–57 billion, a fall of nearly 80 %, more than 200 billion gone. On 21 September 2026, it loses its place in the S&P 100 after 18 years. The company

remains in the S&P 500. It is no longer among the hundred largest. In come infrastructure and cybersecurity.

The All-In conversation and Sacks' clip make the case cultural. The numbers make it financial. Revenue peaked at around USD 51 billion in 2024 and has fallen since. China is faltering. The DTC strategy irritated retail. Hoka and On took the shelf. The campaigns broke with the job the brand was hired to do. No single cause carries 200 billion. The interplay does.

There are two lessons in particular here.

First, a brand premium can be priced as an eternal moat while in practice it is a Roman candle. Buffett warned against exactly that. Nike was valued as if "Just do it" were a perpetual licence on margin. The market has since treated the licence as terminable.

Second, reputational lock-in is a dangerous investment rule and a useful diagnostic. If you shorted everything with a Pride campaign, you lost on most of it. If you ignored the break between job-to-be-done and field signal, plus operational failure, plus lost shelf space, you miss the maturity. Reputational debt is an amplifier, not a law. In a model, it belongs as a shorter growth period and higher risk, not as a moral minus on EPS.

Sacks, quoted in chapter 1, hit the core of the marketing discipline. The job was victory, not the jury. The investor must nevertheless hold two thoughts. The DTC choices of the Donahoe era may have cost more than the Mulvaney ad. Both are losses of optionality. Only one is visible in the feed.

Postcards From The Future

Capital allocation

	Low dependence on the middle phase (machine-readable job, default, protocol)	**High dependence on the middle phase** (film, feed, shelf experience, "brand love"
Job to be done (quality, price, delivery, performance, predictability)	**A. Agent capital** Costco logic, catalogue, fulfilment, API, the ability to be a rule. Hold / increase. The premium may be undervalued because it looks boring	**B. Classic brand in run-off** Strong job, but the job is still done through the eye. Hold with a hedge. Discount the growth period. Demand evidence of mandate migration.
Institutional identity (purpose, politics, field norms, the jury)	**C. Codable constraint** Identity the customer wants as a veto. Rare, valuable. Selective. Only where the constraint is in demand and measurable.	**D. Double maturity** High premium in the multiple, high lock-in in the organization, high funnel risk. Avoid / short with patience.

Box A is the blue ocean. Box D is where institutional debt and the agentic funnel meet. Box B is the large middle of consumer stocks: still a strong brand, but the paradigm is in crisis. There, you should not debate "purpose". There, you should measure how quickly the middle phase is being delegated.

7.4 The platform as a new Porter force, and as a multiple thief

Metcalfe decides who owns the mandate. Muse, Gemini, Copilot, Apple and the wallet layer (Stripe Link, Google Pay, Shop Pay) are not neutral pipes. They are intermediaries taking a share of the orchestration McKinsey estimates at USD 3–5 trillion globally by 2030, and up to 1 trillion in US B2C. The estimate includes both pure agent purchases and human purchases shaped by AI. It is nevertheless enough to shift power.

In Porter's language:

- Switching costs between brands fall (the agent switches in seconds).
- Switching costs towards the platform rise (history, cards, constraints, glasses).
- Supplier power moves towards whoever owns the default and the checkout.
- The threat of substitutes is not another brand. It is that the job gets done without the brand getting a say.

That is why “strong brand, weak protocol” is a value trap. The multiple prices the castle. The purchase goes via a bridge the castle does not own.

Or the other way round: companies that look like low-ROIC infrastructure (PIM systems, fulfilment, returns logistics, product graphs, UCP compatibility) may have option value that does not appear in the brand footnote. They are the rewrite cost Cunningham talked about, paid before the interest eats the growth.

A checklist before you pay for the moat

Use this as due diligence, not as a slogan.

1. Who is the buyer in five years? The share of revenue that can go through mandate + agent without a human seeing an ad.
2. The Damodaran test. What happens to the margin if the brand name is removed – and what happens if the eye is removed, but the catalogue remains?
3. Lock-in versus capital. Which sentences can the company no longer say? Which segments are politically closed? That is interest.
4. Programmability. Does the job exist as attributes, APIs, return rights and delivery data, or only as film?
5. Default or veto. Is the brand a rule in someone’s agent, or a risk in someone’s policy?
6. Protocol. UCP, wallet, single-use cards, provable mandate. Are you visible to whoever executes?
7. Platform risk. How much of the brand equity is really rented attention from Meta and Google, the same companies now building a way around the advertising?
8. Roman candle test. Does today’s ROIC depend on a paradigm in crisis? If so, the growth period in the DCF is the most dangerous cell in the sheet.

Buffett again, on the castle:

«*We are trying to figure out what is keeping — why is that castle still standing? And what's going to keep it standing or cause it not to be standing five, 10, 20 years from now. What are the key factors? And how permanent are they*?»

7.5 Winners and losers in the disruption of the buying process

If digital agents over time replace parts of the human screen, fingers and eyes in the buying process, not all business models will be affected equally. Some companies may get more volume because they sit in the infrastructure the agents need. Others risk having parts of their value moved away from them because the agent takes over search, comparison and the decision itself.

The matrix below is an attempt to sort this landscape. The horizontal axis is about how open a player is to third-party agents. On the left we find companies that let external agents search the catalogue, use the checkout or otherwise act on behalf of the customer. On the right we find players that would rather control the agent themselves, or that try to keep other agents out.

The vertical axis is about the economics when the machine gets more of the mandate. At the top are companies that either charge per transaction or can get more volume when agents buy more often. At the bottom are business models that depend more heavily on humans searching, clicking, being inspired or paying a high margin along the buying journey.

That gives four quite different positions.

Winners and losers in the disruption of the buying process

	Cooperation & open catalogues (agents may buy from them)	**Blocking & walled garden** (own agent or a closed door to others' agents)
Collect a toll or get more volume when machines buy	**1. Clear winners** Infrastructure the agent must use	**2. Fortresses** Own both interface and inventory
Lose "discovery", ads or take rate when the agent holds the mandate	**3. Open with margin risk** Let the agents in, but may become a shelf in others' interfaces (UI)	**4. Relative losers** Weak gate + dependent on humans in search, ads and store visits

Clear winners

In the upper left lies the infrastructure the agents depend on. The point here is simple. The agent can switch shops quite easily. It is harder to switch the infrastructure that makes the purchase possible.

Shopify is a good example. If more and more purchases start in an external agent, Shopify can still sit underneath the catalogue, checkout and payment. In the second quarter of 2026, the company reported strong growth in AI-driven traffic and orders, while structured catalogue data converted better than data that had only been gathered through scraping. The more commerce becomes machine-readable, the more valuable the infrastructure that actually makes goods available to the agent.

Visa and Mastercard have a similar position further down the payment chain. The agent still needs a way to prove intent, authenticate the user and complete the payment. That is why both networks are building solutions around tokenization, agent identity and verifiable mandates. If agentic commerce creates more transaction volume without replacing the card rails, they can in principle benefit from the development.

Companies such as Affirm and FICO may also fit here, but for somewhat different reasons. An agent that optimizes financing costs may prefer more transparent financing products to expensive revolving credit, while credit scoring can still sit underneath the financing regardless of who provides the user interface.

The fortresses

In the upper right are the companies that own both the interface and the marketplace itself. These are the most natural fortresses in agentic commerce, because they do not necessarily need to let other agents in.

Amazon illustrates this well. Rufus acts as the company's own shopping agent inside the Amazon universe, while the company has tried to restrict external agents that want to buy directly on the platform. The logic is understandable. As long as the customer starts at Amazon, Amazon can own the intention, the recommendation and the transaction. The problem arises if the customer's starting point moves to another interface, for example a personal agent in a messaging service.

Meta has a similar strategic opportunity if Muse or other Meta agents become a natural place to start a purchase. Then Meta can move from being a source of attention and advertising to controlling a larger part of the buying journey itself. The upside lies in owning the user's intention before the customer ever reaches the shop. At the same time, the model depends on shops actually letting the Meta agent in.

Open, but with margin risk

In the lower left are players that will probably have to be available to the agents, but that may at the same time lose parts of the economics they used to extract from the buying journey.

Google is perhaps the clearest example. On the one hand, the company has a strong position through Gemini and its own commerce protocols. On the other hand, large parts of today's search economy are built around humans seeing results, clicking on ads and moving on to a website. If an agent can do the search, compare the alternatives and go straight to checkout, parts of this economy may become less valuable.

The same applies to marketplaces and retailers such as Target, eBay and Chewy. They have good reasons to open their catalogues to the agents because they want the traffic. But the more of the user experience moves out of their own surfaces, the greater the risk that they are reduced to a warehouse or an API in the background. They may still get the order, but lose data, brand contact and the ability to influence the customer before the purchase.

That is why this quadrant does not necessarily consist of losers. It consists of companies that may get more volume, but less control over how the value is distributed.

Relative losers

In the lower right we find business models that both have limited control over the agent interface and are vulnerable if humans no longer spend as much time on search, ads and store visits.

Etsy is a good example of the tension. Agentic traffic can bring more volume, but price transparency increases when a machine compares alternatives across sellers and platforms. A high take rate is easier to defend when the user is already inside the marketplace than when an agent can choose the cheapest or most relevant product across the whole web.

Five Below has a different kind of vulnerability. A larger part of the experience is tied to physical discovery, impulse purchases and humans actually walking through the store. That is harder to translate directly to an agent that starts with a concrete task and tries to solve it efficiently.

Google also appears here, in a different role than before. Gemini may be well positioned for agentic commerce, while search and shopping ads may face a harder calculation. That shows why it is important to distinguish between company and business model. The same group can have both winners and losers when the buying journey moves from the human to the agent.

The overall picture is therefore quite simple. The strongest positions lie either beneath the transaction itself or with players that control both the agent and the product. The more exposed business models lie closer to the part of the buying journey that is built around human attention today.

The agent can still buy the same product and use the same payment rails. What changes is who gets to control the road to the purchase. And when that control moves, the margin often moves with it.

8.0 A case study of the Norwegian travel industry

Let us assume a simple and concrete goal for the Norwegian travel industry. *More people should travel to Norway, stay overnight, see and eat*. The analysis so far says that the purchase is increasingly not carried out by the person who wants Norway, but by a digital agent (proxy) that has been given a mandate. The question for Norwegian tourism is therefore not whether Muse and voice commands are "coming to tourism". Travel is the textbook case. We use exactly the trip to Rome as an illustration: where you used to spend half an hour with your fingers, the agent comes back in seconds.

It concerns us because the travel product is a composite buying process (flights, accommodation, transport, experiences, restaurants) and because Norway is already sold through intermediaries. The difference now is that the intermediary stops being a search field you can buy your way into, and becomes a conversation that executes.

Why does this concern the goal?

First, travel is high involvement that is nevertheless delegated. Nobody buys "Norway" like milk. People dream, compare and are afraid of making mistakes. That is exactly why it pays to give the job to an agent. The mandate is human ("fjords, not too expensive, northern lights if possible, avoid the worst queues"). The execution is done by machines.

Second, we do not own the funnel itself today. Booking.com, Expedia, Airbnb, Google Flights/Hotels and the airlines own the middle phase. Innovation Norway's own figures show a record 40.6 million commercial guest nights in 2025, foreign overnight stays up 14 %, and July 2026 with 4 million hotel nights. At the same time, the share via sharing and booking platforms has risen sharply. In one estimate, from 20 % of guest nights in 2019 to 31 % in 2025. The commission leakage is already documented. The agent builds on that track, not on visitnorway.com.

Skift tested Muse on travel the week after launch: flights go via direct infrastructure (Duffel), hotels are bought like a human would in the browser on the consumer sites. Google AI Mode is rolling out hotel booking with Booking, Expedia, Hilton, Marriott and others as merchant of record. ChatGPT has had Expedia and Booking apps, with restrictions in the EU/UK. The point is not which logo wins. The point is that "plan and book the whole trip" is already the product promise. Norway becomes a search result inside that promise, or it does not.

Third, the goal itself is a mandate, and mandates can contradict each other. The national tourism strategy wants more jobs and more exports, and halved emissions, and high-value guests with a low footprint, and spread across geography and season, and satisfied residents. Visit Norway has pulled campaigns when pressure on nature became too high. Lofoten and Tromsø know the capacity limit. A tourist tax and emission requirements in the World Heritage fjords are constraints. An agent optimizing "see Norway as cheaply as possible in July" works against parts of the goal. An agent given the mandate "Norway in September, at least two regions, local food, avoid cruise shock" works with it. Who writes the mandate is therefore not a communications detail. It is demand management.

How does it affect the four goals?

Travel

Flights and long-distance transport are the part of the funnel that is automated first. Live inventory, price, layovers and punctuality: that is machine-readable. Muse already runs on flight data. Google tracks prices in more than 180 countries. Here, the "destination film" does not win. Here, route networks, open seats, predictable arrival and a mandate that has Norway as its geography win, not just "Northern Europe" or "fjords somewhere".

Why does it sting? Norway is expensive and peripheral. The agent, without shame, will often suggest Scotland, Iceland or northern Sweden if the mandate is "northern lights and nature under a cap". The brand equity "Norway is different" only survives if it is coded as a constraint or as a unique job (northern lights probability, Hurtigruten, specific fjords, seasonal window), not as a mood.

When will it happen? Now for research and price comparison. 2026–2028 for booking inside the conversation in large markets. Norway/the EU may lag behind the US on full checkout in ChatGPT apps, but Google and browser agents do not recognize Schengen as an ideological border. The fingers are already on their way out of the flight search.

Stay overnight

Hotels and cabins are the OTAs' home ground, and therefore the agent's. Google AI Mode books through precisely Booking and Expedia. Muse shops for hotels in an open browser. Visibility in the OTA graph is then the entry ticket, and your own websites without structured data are invisible.

It affects volume, where foreign guests are driving the records. It affects margins, where commission and leakage rise when the intermediary becomes smarter and takes a larger part of the evaluation. It also affects the spread, where the agent chooses whatever has inventory, reviews, cancellation rules and pictures in a format it can read. The mountain hotel without an updated calendar, the small guesthouse

without an API, the destination that only exists in a brochure, fall out of the consideration set.

The lock-in from chapter A shows up here as season and capacity rhetoric. If, in the international corpus, we are first and foremost “expensive, full in July, queues at Preikestolen”, that becomes a veto, not a magnet. If we are “high, predictable quality, September, night train, slow”, it can become the default for a different mandate.

Sightseeing and experiences

This is the weakest link in the agent’s graph, and therefore both the threat and the opportunity. Experiences in Norway are fragmented. A kayak, a guide, a ticket for a glacier walk, a bus to Trolltunga, a northern lights alert. Many have neither APIs, stable opening hours nor cancellation rules a machine dares to trust.

If the agent nevertheless has to “fill the days”, it will fall back on what is industrially packaged: cruises, big tours, Tripadvisor top lists, the same five fjords. Then we get more of what the destination strategy does not want, such as pressure on the icons, empty shoulder seasons, or local wear and tear.

But whoever makes the experience machine-readable and bookable (time slot, weather dependency, skill level, sustainability requirements, meeting point) can become the constraint owner. “Not Preikestolen on a July weekend, but this route in week 37” is a mandate. It is also product development.

Sightseeing is also where the glasses come in later. Words plus field of view. “What is that mountain, can we get there this afternoon, book it”. Then the destination’s enemy is not Booking. It is the lack of real-time inventory.

Eat

Restaurants are already partly agentified internationally (OpenTable, reservations in Google). In Norway, there is still a lot of phone, Facebook and “drop in”. The Michelin list is machine-readable and will be overweighted. The local eatery without a

reservation interface becomes invisible to the proxy that has to "find dinner in Ålesund tonight".

The goal of "eating in Norway" is value creation per guest, not just a hot dog at the viewpoint. The agent easily optimizes for whatever has a table, a rating and a short walk from the hotel it booked itself. The food follows the accommodation. If the OTA owns the hotel in the graph, it also owns the evening's restaurant card, unless the destination feeds the agent its own bookable food offering.

Here lies a programmable constraint that actually hits the strategy, with "local food", "seasonal", "not an international chain". That is identity that can become a mandate, not a purpose film. Chapter A: such signals survive. "We believe in sustainability" does not survive unless it means something in the filter.

8.1 When does this start to concern the "travel industry"?

The timeline is uneven, and that is the point. You should not wait for "everyone booking with glasses".

Postcards From The Future

When does this concern the travel industry?

Phase	When	What happens to the Norway goal
Research	Already under way	The agent and chat search for "Norway itinerary". The corpus (reviews, prices, queues, weather) shapes consideration. Film without data loses.
Assembly		The whole trip is planned in one conversation. Destinations without packageable logic (flight+night+two days+food) become too heavy.
Booking flights and hotels	2026–2028 in large markets	Muse, Google AI Mode, OTA agents. Visibility = inventory at the partners they use.
Experiences and restaurants	2027–2030	Lagging. The winner is whoever becomes bookable before it is consensus.
Glasses/situated command	After hardware adoption	On-trip: "book that house", "find dinner". Requires real-time data.
Mandate as steering	Can start now	Visit Norway and destinations do not just write campaigns. They write rules people can give the agent.

"When" is therefore not 2030. The domestic market (Norwegians holidaying in Norway) meets the same agents. Statistics Norway shows that Norwegians took 9.8

million holiday trips in Norway in the first half of 2026. They too will say “find a long weekend under NOK 8,000 with good food”. If Sørlandet is not in the answer, they go to Gothenburg.

Reputational debt in Norwegian travel

Norway has a brand that resembles box A in chapter 4.5: the job-to-be-done is nature, calm, quality, safety. It is real. The lock-in arises when we load it with signals that cannot be operationalized, or that contradict capacity.

Two interest items are already visible.

One is the icon trap. We have sold Preikestolen, Geiranger, Lofoten and the northern lights so effectively that the agent, which loves top lists, will send even more people to the same places. The field rewards iconic images. Residents and the strategy reward spread. That is institutional debt: the last campaign makes the next steering signal more expensive.

The other is the expensive-and-full corpus. An average hotel room price of around NOK 1,600 in July 2026, and stories of wear and tear, go into what the agent “knows” about Norway. A brand film about silence does not change that dataset. Operations do: more bookable shoulder-season products, honest capacity signals, prices that follow the season, not shame.

Reputational lock-in is less relevant here as a culture war than as a warning against signals without a job. Sustainability campaigns that cannot become filters (“zero-emission fjord”, “avoid day cruises”, “stay at least four nights”) are field language. The same requirements, coded as a mandate, are a product.

8.2 Moats in a country without Disneyland

Norway’s moat is not the brand film. It is the combination of geography that cannot be copied and predictable delivery in weather that can ruin a day. Buffett’s castle only stands here if the road in goes through a mandate that needs exactly this geography.

Iceland, Scotland and Canada are substitutes in the agent's evaluation. The differentiation must be specific enough to survive a price comparison.

The well-established models that break are the same as in the concluding chapter, translated to the industry. The destination company that lives off buying eyeballs in Germany. The hotel that lives off its Booking placement without its own graph, the experience company that lives off someone googling and calling, the restaurants that live off passers-by at the viewpoint. The finger on the keyboard was how the German found Lofoten. The word is how the agent chooses between Lofoten, Senja and Vesterålen, or drops Norway.

Are there any answers to how, why and when for the Norwegian travel industry?

Why? Because the goal is a buying process, and the buying process is what is being disrupted. More trips, nights, sights and meals assume that someone chooses Norway and then follows through. The choice and the follow-through are moving into a conversation we do not own.

How? Through flights and hotels being automated first via OTAs and agents, through experiences and food lagging behind and therefore becoming either icon congestion or a blue ocean for whoever becomes bookable, through the brand "Norway" being compressed into what the corpus and catalogue actually contain, or through the strategy's sustainability and spread goals only surviving as constraints in the mandate, not as jury copy.

When? In analysis and research, we are already there. Flights and accommodation in large markets this cycle, 2026–2028. Experiences, food and glasses shortly after. Steering through the mandate can start this autumn. Write the products so that a German can say "do it" to Muse, Gemini or the Booking agent, and get the whole country and the whole year, not just July in the same five places.

If we keep buying attention as if the finger were still in the search field, we are financing interest on a funnel that is losing its subject. If we build inventory, rules and

sentences a machine can keep, the voice command is not a threat to the goal. It is the new way the goal can be reached, provided that "more" means more of the right nights, not just more bodies in the queue for what we have already sold well.

Postcards From The Future

Norwegian travel when the agent books

INTERPRETATION \ SIGNAL	**Job to be done** room, slot, train, table, weather window, cancellation	**Icon and identity** fjord mood, "powered by nature", purpose without a filter
Human	**A. Destination capital** The product withstands a glance and a click. Hurtigruten as transport + accommodation. The Bergen Line. A family hotel with an honest calendar and price.	**B. Campaign debt** The jury nods. Capacity does not. Icon films of Preikestolen and Lofoten in July. Sustainability copy that cannot become a filter. Destination awards for "visibility" without bookable inventory.
Digital agent with mandate	**C. Agent capital** Default or a row in the utility function. "Northern lights weeks 6–10, Troms, cancellable." Kayak at 09:00 in week 37. A restaurant table in Ålesund tonight. Shoulder season packaged as a rule.	**D. Double queue** The agent loves top lists. The place drowns. Geiranger and Trolltunga as eternal Tripadvisor firsts. Expensive-and-full in the corpus. "See Norway" without a region, without a night, without food – just the icon.

Marketing does not disappear when the agent arrives. But a larger part of the competition moves from influencing human attention to influencing which alternatives the agent is allowed to consider at all. Brands therefore do not become less important everywhere. They become more binary. The strongest brands can be coded in as defaults. The weakest are reduced to comparable rows. In between lie companies that still pay for attention in a buying process they are gradually losing control over. Brands used to compete to be remembered. Now the competition is about being chosen before the human has a chance to see the alternatives.

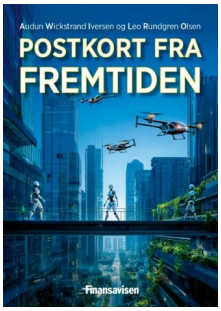
Thank you very much for reading.

See you in the future.

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